

U13-U16 PLAYER & TEAM DEVELOPMENT

Soccer Development Handbook

Intelligent, technical, courageous soccer

PRACTICE **SCAN. TALK. INTENTION. FASTER.**

GAMES **CALM MIND. FAST SOCCER.**

MISTAKES **RESPOND. REFLECT. LEARN. NEXT PLAY.**

PRESSURE **WANT THE MOMENT.**

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Contents

Introduction	1
For Players	3
High-Level Player Sheet	4
Team Culture, Courage, Leadership & Self-Coaching	8
Injuries, Recovery, and Return to Play	16
Communication & Movement Fundamentals	21
Film Review Guide	26
Home Development Menu	33
Position Cards	40
Goalkeeper #1	41
Outside Back #2 / #3	42
Center Back #4 / #5	43
Defensive Midfielder / Pivot #6 / #8	44
Winger #7 / #11	45
Striker #9	46
Attacking Midfielder #10	47
For Coaches and Parents	48
Coaching Game Model & Development Manual	49
What Good Coaching Looks Like	85
Parent Partnership	89
Templates and Resources	92
Weekend Role Sheet	93
Game Reflection	94
Development Plan	95
Sources and Further Reading	96

Introduction

A practical player-development and team-coaching handbook for a U13–U14 girls’ ECNL Regional League team, built around intelligent, technical, courageous soccer. The framework applies across U13–U16.

Version 1.0 · September 2026. Laws, safety policies, league structures, and media sources in this handbook change; check them each season.

The central goal is not to create players who memorize instructions. It is to develop players who can **scan, communicate, make intentional decisions, solve problems, compete, reflect, lead, and adapt**. They should also understand how they learn, well enough to take part in their own development instead of simply being the product of whatever coaching reaches them.

Core team mantras

Players say the mantras out loud, together: the practice mantra is the first thing at every practice, and the game mantra is the first thing in every game warm-up.

Moment	Mantra
Practice	SCAN. TALK. INTENTION. FASTER.
Games	CALM MIND. FAST SOCCER.
After mistakes	RESPOND. REFLECT. LEARN. NEXT PLAY.
Pressure moments	WANT THE MOMENT.

The middle gear

The handbook also emphasizes **possession at multiple scales**. Players should be able to combine in tight spaces, but also recognize when pressure has been escaped and the field has opened.

SMALL SPACE: COMBINE. BIG SPACE: EXPLOIT.

We want to eliminate the common youth pattern of **short passing under pressure → continued short passing after escape → panic clearance**.

We want to replace it with:

Combine → escape → expand → exploit space with intention.

The full explanation and training progression are in §7 of the Coaching Game Model & Development Manual.

How to use this handbook

Players

- Know the four mantras by memory. Learn the bold principles in the [High-Level Player Sheet](#) over time, and use it as a quick reference.
- Read [Team Culture, Courage, Leadership & Self-Coaching](#) for the ideas behind the sheet.
- Learn the team's shared words, body shape, and movement habits in [Communication & Movement Fundamentals](#).
- Before each match, review the [position card](#) for your role and picture its moments.
- Study your games with the [Film Review Guide](#), and choose short sessions from the [Home Development Menu](#).
- If something hurts, tell a parent and your coach, and read [Injuries, Recovery, and Return to Play](#).

Coaches

- Teach from the [Coaching Game Model & Development Manual](#), which holds the tactical detail and the development system.
- Check the environment against [What Good Coaching Looks Like](#).
- Plan and follow up with the templates: [Weekend Role Sheet](#), [Game Reflection](#), and [Development Plan](#).
- When a player is hurt, follow [Injuries, Recovery, and Return to Play](#): respect medical restrictions, keep her connected, and never reward a hidden injury.

Parents

- Start with [Parent Partnership](#): the sideline, after the game, helping at home, health signals, communication and safeguarding, and team film.
- Use [What Good Coaching Looks Like](#) to see whether the team is learning, not just winning.
- After a meaningful injury, read [Injuries, Recovery, and Return to Play](#) for what to share with the coach and how the return works.

Roles and privacy

Position numbers follow the common U.S. 1–11 numbering; the right side takes the lower number. **Shareable documents use roles and positions only, never player names.** Each player receives only her own Weekend Role Sheet row, in person or through the team app with parents included, and development feedback happens face to face at the field, in view of others.

Philosophy

Winning matters, and players should want to win.

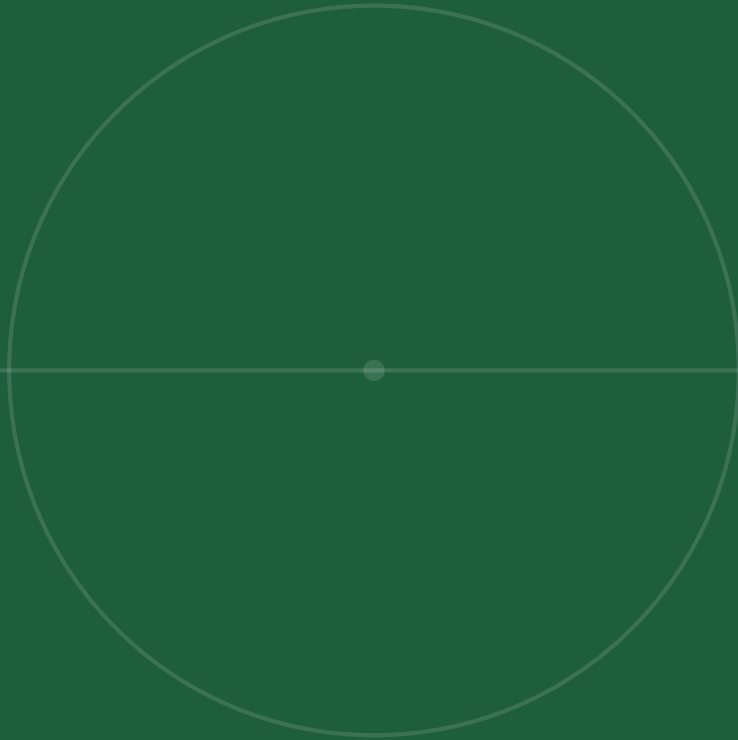
Winning is not the primary measure of development, but competing to win is part of development.

The system itself should keep improving: attached to sound principles, not to one method, with training, roles, and constraints evolving as players develop. The principles were checked against federation, academy, and research sources (see [Sources and Further Reading](#)) but are not an official program of any of them.

PART ONE

For Players

The principles, language, and habits every player should own.



High-Level Player Sheet

This is the short version. Know the four mantras by memory. Learn the bold principles over time, and use this sheet as a quick reference. The fuller explanations live in [Team Culture, Courage, Leadership & Self-Coaching](#) and, for how we play, [Communication & Movement Fundamentals](#).

Our four team mantras

We say our mantras out loud, together: the practice mantra is the first thing we say at every practice; the game mantra is the first thing we say in every game warm-up.

Practice

SCAN. TALK. INTENTION. FASTER.

- **Scan:** collect information before you need it.
- **Talk:** give teammates useful information they cannot see.
- **Intention:** every action should have a reason.
- **Faster:** push the speed at which the first three can still be done correctly.

Games

CALM MIND. FAST SOCCER.

Fast soccer does not mean panic. It means seeing early, deciding quickly, and executing with control. Playing quickly is not getting rid of the ball quickly: it can mean holding it an extra second because you already scanned, playing backward, or carrying 15 yards because nobody stepped.

After mistakes

RESPOND. REFLECT. LEARN. NEXT PLAY.

Creative play and risk-taking will create mistakes. Mistakes should be learning moments, never reasons for shame or embarrassment.

Pressure moments

WANT THE MOMENT.

Nerves are normal. They are your body getting ready. Step forward anyway.

How we want to play

No hiding. No watching. Influence the game.

At every moment, ask: **Where could I go right now that would make me useful?**

Four moments and our shape

- Think in four moments: **when we have it, when we lose it, when they have it, when we win it.** Your **position card** uses the same frame.
- The formation is a starting structure, not fixed spots. **Preserve the relationships, not the coordinates.**
- Midfield triangle: **One shows. One protects. One threatens.**
- Front line: **Exchange positions without losing attacking shape.** The 9 and 10: **One comes. One goes.**
- Building from the back: **Safe does not automatically mean clearance.** The goalkeeper is part of possession. Read the press: **Short invites the press. Long punishes it. Choose on purpose.**

Details are in the **Coaching Game Model**, §4, §16, and §18–19.

When we have it

- Everyone is a potential outlet. Not being an option makes the ball carrier's problem harder.
- Move on the pass. Move again after you pass.
- Use width, depth, different heights, and good spacing. Strong side attracts. Weak side prepares.
- Look diagonal, sideways, backward, and forward.
- Progress when we have an advantage. Keep the ball when we don't.
- Show one thing and do another. Look like you're changing your mind.

When the field opens

Rondos teach us how to survive when the game gets small. Soccer also requires us to recognize when the game becomes big.

- When we escape pressure, recognize that the problem has changed. Look up.
- Do not keep playing five-yard passes in the same crowded area after the field opens.
- Carry open grass, switch the field, find a runner, or attack before the defense recovers.
- A longer pass with a clear purpose is not a clearance.
- **Find the biggest useful space.**

SMALL SPACE: COMBINE. BIG SPACE: EXPLOIT.

The goal is not to pass short or to pass long. The goal is to recognize the space and use the right solution.

Without the ball and in transition

- Protect dangerous space first. Get tighter as the ball and danger get closer.
- Protect the middle and delay when necessary.
- On loss: counterpress if we can win it; otherwise recover into shape immediately.
- Defend from a position you can attack from.
- Head with purpose, not habit.

Brave soccer

We want players to turn, carry, dribble, disguise passes, **play through pressure**, combine, and try creative solutions when they recognize the opportunity.

We will correct careless decisions, but we will not punish intelligent ideas simply because they did not work.

Careless means ignoring the picture in front of you or what we have worked on in training.

In the game: respond, then play the next action. Later (at a break, after the game, or on film), reflect with the five questions in [Team Culture: Mistakes are learning moments](#).

Want the moment

The goal is not to eliminate fear. The goal is to stop fear from making the decision. At U14, the real loss is not missing the penalty. The real loss is avoiding the chance to learn how you respond under pressure.

We should fear wasting developmental opportunities more than we fear temporary failure.

You may be nervous. You may miss. Neither is shameful. Wanting the moment never means playing through pain or hiding an injury. Tell a parent and your coach what hurts; see [Injuries, Recovery, and Return to Play](#). For the pressure routine and penalty kicks, see [Team Culture: Want the moment](#).

Compete to win, develop for the long term

Winning is not the primary measure of development, but competing to win is part of development.

That means: **Want to win. Play for the next action, not the scoreboard.**

Everyone leads

Leadership belongs to every player, not only captains. Not every leader is loud. See [Team Culture: Everyone leads](#).

See what the team needs, and help provide it.

Coach yourself

Be coachable — and learn to coach yourself.

In games, self-coaching is a loop: scan → understand → decide → execute → reflect → adjust. See [Team Culture: Every player is also her own coach](#).

After every practice, ask: **What soccer problem did today's practice teach me to solve?**

Training shapes habits, including through what it leaves out. Notice what you get lots of reps at and what you get almost none of, and fill the gaps deliberately. **Your coach shapes your environment. You still own your development.** See [Team Culture: How training shapes you](#).

Team development culture

Your effort is part of your teammate's training.

We compete hard against each other **to make each other better, not to rank each other**. See [Team Culture: Your effort is part of your teammate's training](#).

Peer support

Help each other learn. Don't grade each other.

See [Team Culture: Help each other learn](#).

- Describe, don't judge. Ask before giving advice.
- Use shared team language. Praise useful behavior specifically.
- Support teammates after mistakes. Body language counts: no sighs or eye-rolls.
- In games, give information and encouragement. Save advice for later.
- Leave selection, discipline, and major corrections to the coach.

Development ownership

Know one current strength to build on, one current development priority chosen with the coach, and what progress would look like. These change as you improve. No priority yet? Draft one and ask the coach whether it's right. **Your team role is where you help the team today. Your development role is the complete player you are becoming.**

Want a different role or more minutes? Ask the coach yourself: **"What would I need to show to earn that?"** Talk with the coach during office hours at the field, or send a film question through the team app, with a parent included. See [Team Culture: Asking for opportunities](#).

Team Culture, Courage, Leadership & Self-Coaching

This document describes the developmental culture we want around the team. The [High-Level Player Sheet](#) states each idea in a line or two; this is where they are explained.

Tactics and technique matter. But players also need courage, responsibility, self-awareness, leadership, and the ability to keep learning without waiting for a coach to provide every answer.

Want the moment

Youth soccer gives us chances to practice courage before the stakes are truly high. Pressure is not something to avoid. It is something to learn from.

A penalty kick, difficult pass, 1v1 duel, late-game shot, or moment of leadership can feel enormous. But these are primarily development opportunities.

At U14, the real loss is not missing the penalty. The real loss is avoiding the chance to learn how you respond under pressure.

Nerves are normal. They are your body getting ready. The goal is not to eliminate fear. The goal is to stop fear from making the decision.

WANT THE MOMENT.

- Step forward.
- Ask for the ball.
- Take the shot.
- Step into the duel.
- Take the penalty.
- Try the difficult action.
- Speak up when the team needs information.
- Accept responsibility.

You may succeed. You may fail. Either way, you gain experience that prepares you for harder moments later.

We should fear wasting developmental opportunities more than we fear temporary failure.

You may be nervous. You may miss. Neither is shameful. A missed penalty can teach composure, routine, courage, technique, and emotional recovery. A penalty you were too afraid to take teaches much less.

This applies far beyond penalty kicks. We want players who think: “This is hard. Good. I want the chance to learn from it.” At this age, one result will soon be forgotten. The confidence, courage, and experience gained by stepping into difficult moments can stay with you for years.

A useful routine for any pressure moment is **Breathe → decide → commit → execute**. Then, whatever the result: **RESPOND. REFLECT. LEARN. NEXT PLAY.**

Wanting the moment never means playing through pain or hiding an injury. Tell a parent and your coach what hurts; see [Injuries, Recovery, and Return to Play](#).

Penalty kicks

Pick. Place. Breathe. Strike.

1. Pick your spot before the walk. Stick with it.
2. Place the ball carefully. No rushing.
3. After the whistle, take one breath with your eyes on your spot.
4. Strike your spot with commitment.

Everyone trains to be ready. Tell the coach during the week if you want a kick; the coach sets the order before the game.

In a shootout:

- Scored? Celebrate with your team. It can lift the next kicker.
- Missed? Head up, and walk back to your team. **RESPOND. REFLECT. LEARN. NEXT PLAY.**
- Teammates stand together and go to every kicker, scored or missed.

Mistakes are learning moments

Creative soccer requires risk.

Players are being asked to receive under pressure, turn, carry, dribble, disguise passes, play through lines, combine, rotate, and make increasingly independent decisions. Mistakes are inevitable.

A turnover does not automatically mean the decision was poor. We will not punish intelligent ideas simply because they did not work. We still coach hard on careless decisions, ignoring what we have worked on in training, and not recovering after a mistake.

In the game: respond, then play the next action.

Respond and next play take seconds. Reflect and learn come later, at a break, after the game, or on film. Then ask:

1. What did I see?
2. What information did I miss?
3. Was the decision reasonable?
4. Did the execution fail?
5. What can I try next time?

Mistakes should lead to insight, never shame. Teammates support rather than blame, ridicule, or make a player afraid to try an intelligent action again.

Team reset

The players choose one shared reset gesture, for example brushing the shoulder. After a mistake, the player uses it herself. Teammates and coaches add “Next play.” We practice it in training so it is automatic in games.

Everyone leads

Captains have a formal role. Leadership does not. Every player should learn how to lead.

Leadership can mean:

- communicating clearly
- speaking when the team needs direction
- encouraging a teammate after a mistake
- setting the effort standard in practice
- organizing defensive shape
- helping a teammate understand a concept
- volunteering for difficult moments
- staying composed when others are frustrated
- taking responsibility

Not every leader is loud. Some lead through communication, some through effort, and some through composure, courage, or helping others understand the game.

See what the team needs, and help provide it.

The goal is not one or two leaders surrounded by followers. **We want a team of leaders.**

Players should get chances to lead warm-ups, explain team principles, organize small groups, help with film review, communicate during tactical work, and help solve team problems.

Leadership also requires humility. Helping teammates is not the same as controlling or criticizing them.

Every player is also her own coach

A coach cannot see every moment, solve every problem, or provide every bit of motivation. Every player should gradually learn to coach herself. That means becoming a student of the game.

Players should learn to:

- notice patterns
- identify problems
- ask questions
- study better players
- review film
- understand strengths and weaknesses
- set personal development goals

- reflect after mistakes
- recognize when something is not working and try a different solution

Be coachable — and learn to coach yourself.

Becoming your own coach does not mean ignoring your coach. It means understanding why things work.

In a game, self-coaching looks like: **scan → understand → decide → execute → reflect → adjust.**

After every practice, ask: **What soccer problem did today's practice teach me to solve?** The answer might be escaping pressure, switching the field, creating a 2v1, finding a teammate between the lines, or defending a 2v2.

The coach provides guidance, structure, feedback, and perspective. You own your development.

How training shapes you

Coaching yourself also means understanding how your environment teaches you. **What practice repeatedly shows you becomes what you learn to see and solve.** If you get almost no reps at something, it is hard to become good at it, however hard you work. **Your environment will shape you. Learn from it, but do not let its limitations become your limitations.**

So a pattern can look like a player problem and be partly a training problem:

- Mostly tight-space possession work can produce a team that keeps passing short after escaping pressure, then clears in a panic.
- If teammates are not taught to become options, the ball carrier is left forcing it forward, then blamed for having no option. Pressure is a team problem.
- Where intelligent mistakes get punished, players stop turning, dribbling, and trying things.
- Constant instructions can leave players waiting to be told instead of reading the game. Ask what you saw and what else was possible, and learn the reason behind an instruction.
- Rules like “two touch” or “stay wide” are useful teaching tools, but players can keep obeying them after the picture has changed. Learn what problem a rule solves.
- Early size or speed can steer a player into a narrow role that may not fit the player she becomes. Current usefulness is not developmental destiny.
- Low-touch roles without extra reps in training leave on-ball skills behind. Replace the missing reps with small-sided games, rondos, wall work, and pickup.

Reasonable coaches use different methods, and one session proves little. Something important missing for weeks is different. Notice it, because it will shape your habits.

Your coach shapes your environment. You still own your development. Take responsibility for your development without taking responsibility for every failure in your environment.

Ask yourself:

- What problem is this practice trying to solve, and what am I being asked to notice?
- What am I getting lots of reps at? What am I getting almost none of?
- What game problem keeps coming back that we are not working on?
- Am I following this rule because I understand the principle, or because I was told to?

- What do I need to develop outside my current role?
- What should I ask my coach, and what can I solve myself?

Then act on it: study the pattern on [film](#), fill the gap with the [Home Development Menu](#) and pickup games, look for the reps you are missing, and ask the coach a good question (for example, “When we break pressure, what should I be looking for?”). For what an environment may be teaching well or leaving out, see [What Good Coaching Looks Like](#).

Not every gap is yours to close. **Some gaps you can fill yourself. Some you can partly compensate for. Some require the team or coach to change. Know the difference.** You can build your weak foot on your own. You can partly make up for a low-touch role with extra reps. You cannot teach ten teammates to press together. For that kind of gap, ask a good question at office hours, keep modeling the habit, and don’t carry it as your fault.

Avoid both extremes: “The coach is always right, so just be more coachable” and “The coach is wrong, so ignore the coach.”

**Be coachable. Think independently. Understand why.
Notice what is missing. Keep developing anyway.**

Team role and development role

**Your team role is where you help the team today.
Your development role is the complete player you are becoming.**

Say “I am a complete soccer player who can currently help my team at ____” — not “I am a ____.”

- In rondos and small-sided games, build what your match role does not give you: receive, turn, carry, and combine.
- Ask yourself: “How do I make sure I still become the player I want to become?”
- You can be a great teammate and ambitious.

Being useful to the team today and becoming a complete player are both valid goals. They are not always automatically aligned. Reliability can keep a player in one role: a dependable center back may stay there all season with few touches on the ball. Protect both goals:

- Seek reps in the skills your role doesn’t give you, and use training intentionally.
- Ask for rotation, or for role-specific work that builds what you’re missing.
- Watch film of other roles, not only your own.
- Don’t define yourself by one current position.

Asking for opportunities

Want a different role, more minutes, or more chances to develop part of your game? Ask the coach yourself: **“What would I need to show to earn that?”**

- Talk about your own development, not what teammates deserve: “My current role is not giving me enough chances to develop ____.”
- Ask for something specific: “Could I get some minutes at ____ so I can work on receiving and combining?”

- Show the qualities of the role you want in the role you have.
- You do the talking. A parent can help you prepare.
- Book up to 5 minutes of office hours, in person or through the team app with a parent included. The talk itself happens at the field, in view of others.

No development priority yet, or none for a long stretch? Effort without a target turns into vague development, and you can respond to it. Draft your own: one strength to build, one current priority, and one observable sign of progress. Bring it to office hours and ask, “Is this the right priority?” Record it on the [Development Plan](#).

Help each other learn

Players should coach and assist each other in a healthy way.

Help each other learn. Don't grade each other.

Good peer support includes:

- useful information
- questions
- demonstrations
- encouragement
- specific praise
- sharing what you saw
- helping a teammate understand a team concept

Avoid:

- blame
- bossiness
- public criticism
- sarcasm
- acting like another player's authority

Tactical disagreement is allowed. Different players may see different good solutions.

Body language counts. No sighs, eye-rolls, or arms-out after a teammate's mistake. In games, give information and encouragement. Save advice for later.

When the culture slips

When a team lacks clear standards around mistakes, risk, communication, and leadership, teammates can start blaming, criticizing, eye-rolling, or policing each other. That spreads fear, and fear shuts down courage and creativity. Don't join the blame cycle. Help build a better culture:

- Support teammates after mistakes.
- Give information instead of judgment.
- Praise useful actions.
- Separate the decision from the outcome.

- Compete hard without ranking teammates socially.
- Lead constructively, with or without an armband.

Group chats and body talk

Peer feedback lives on the field, not in the group chat. Never share a teammate's mistake in a group chat or a story.

Talk about what bodies can do, never how they look.

Praise strong, fast, balanced, and brave. No comments about weight, shape, or appearance, whether about a teammate or anyone else.

Your effort is part of your teammate's training

Every player contributes to the quality of every teammate's development.

If you defend casually, your teammate does not learn to beat realistic pressure. If you jog through a transition, teammates do not learn to solve a realistic transition. If you move, communicate, press, compete, and play with intensity, you create better repetitions for everyone around you.

We compete hard against each other to make each other better, not to rank each other.

Growth is not a zero-sum competition. A better teammate creates a better practice opponent, a better game partner, and a better environment for everyone.

Competitive mentality

Winning is not the primary measure of development, but competing to win is part of development.

Players should want to win. They should care, compete, defend, recover, communicate, and take responsibility.

Want to win. Play for the next action, not the scoreboard.

No player carries a result alone. Losses are team problems to solve, never one player's fault.

Coaches should not sacrifice long-term development simply to improve a temporary scoreline. A team can lose while developing well and win while developing poorly.

The goal is to combine:

- long-term perspective from coaches
- competitive urgency from players
- courage to develop while still trying to win

The culture we want

We want players who:

- want difficult moments
- step into pressure moments instead of hiding
- support teammates and help them improve
- lead without needing an armband
- take responsibility
- learn from mistakes
- study the game and solve problems
- motivate themselves
- leave this age group knowing how to keep teaching themselves

Injuries, Recovery, and Return to Play

IN THIS CHAPTER

Health comes first	16	Return progressively	19
What toughness means	17	Do not be afraid of the game	19
Communication after an injury	17	Teammates should respect the return process ...	19
Take care of your teammates	18	Coaches should never reward hidden injuries	20
The injured player is still part of the team	18	When a player returns	20
Do not make the injury her identity	18	The team standard	20
Returning can be mentally difficult	18		

Injuries are part of sports. We should prepare for them without becoming afraid of them. Our goals are to:

- protect the player’s health
- support the injured player emotionally
- keep her connected to the team
- communicate clearly with parents and coaches
- respect appropriate medical guidance
- help the player return without unnecessary fear
- create a team culture that cares about people more than availability for the next game

Health comes first

A player’s long-term health matters more than a practice, tournament, league game, or season. Players should never feel pressure to hide an injury because they are afraid of losing playing time, disappointing teammates, or appearing weak. Reporting an injury honestly is responsible. Following treatment and rehabilitation is responsible. Taking the time needed to recover is responsible.

Sore muscles the day after a hard or new workout are common and ease with rest. Pain that starts while you play is different. Stop and tell a parent and your coach if:

- something starts to hurt while you play, especially an old injury
- you are limping or moving differently to protect it
- it is swollen, or you can’t move it normally
- the pain is very bad, getting worse, or not getting better with rest

A limp, swelling, not being able to move it normally, very bad pain, or pain or swelling that gets worse or does not go away after a few days means see a doctor. Growing players: also see [Home Development Menu: Pain rule](#).

After a blow to the head or body, tell your coach right away, and come out if you feel dazed, dizzy, or “not right.” Watch for these in yourself or a teammate: dazed or confused, slow to answer, unsteady,

a change in mood, headache, dizziness, nausea, vision problems, bothered by light or noise, or feeling foggy. Any of these: come out, and unless a health care professional on site clears you, you are done for the day. **When in doubt, sit out.** A concussion follows its own step-by-step plan led by your health care provider, with no contact, heading, or full training until you are cleared. See [Parent Partnership: Health signals and Coaching Game Model: Returning after a concussion](#).

What toughness means

We respect the toughness of athletes. But toughness does not mean ignoring an injury. Toughness can mean:

- telling the truth when something hurts
- accepting that you may temporarily be unable to play
- doing rehabilitation consistently
- staying mentally engaged while injured
- supporting teammates while you recover
- dealing patiently with setbacks
- returning with courage when you are ready

We should respect the work an injured teammate is doing to return. We should never pressure her to prove toughness by playing before she is ready.

Communication after an injury

Parents should communicate with the coach after a meaningful injury. When appropriate, please share:

- the general nature and extent of the injury
- any medical restrictions that affect soccer
- the expected recovery process or timeline, if one is known
- when the player may begin practicing again
- any limitations during the return process

The purpose is not for the coach to make medical decisions. The purpose is for the coach to understand how to support the player safely. Medical diagnosis, rehabilitation, and clearance decisions belong with the player, parents, and appropriate health care professionals. The coach should respect medical restrictions completely. Within those limits, the coach plans her training and game minutes.

She should have a voice in her own plan. The details of her injury belong to her and her family. The coach shares with the team only what she and her family agree to, and the adults who run practice are told her limits. Coach messages to her about the injury include a parent, like every coach message.

Take care of your teammates

When a teammate gets hurt, let her know that she matters beyond what she contributes on the field. Send her a message. Ask how she is doing. Tell her you are thinking about her. Tell her you are looking forward to having her back. Keep including her.

A simple message such as “Hope you’re doing okay. We miss you and can’t wait to have you back” can mean a great deal to an injured teammate. Players should not disappear socially from the team simply because they temporarily cannot play.

The injured player is still part of the team

When appropriate and comfortable for the player, injured players should remain connected. That might include:

- attending games or practices
- participating in team meetings
- watching film
- helping observe tactical problems
- encouraging teammates
- learning a new position or concept
- staying part of the team socially

None of this should become an obligation when the player needs rest, treatment, school time, or emotional space. The goal is connection, not guilt.

Do not make the injury her identity

Ask about the player, not only the injury. An injured athlete can quickly feel as though every conversation begins with “How’s the knee?” or “When are you coming back?” Check in, but also talk to her normally. She is still the same teammate.

Feeling sad, angry, frustrated, or left out after an injury is common. If those feelings are not easing or are getting worse, or if she pulls away from friends or her sleep or eating changes a lot, players tell a parent and coaches tell her family. Talking with a counselor or doctor is part of recovery, just like rehab. If she talks about hurting herself, get help right away: call or text 988, or call 911 in an emergency.

Returning can be mentally difficult

Being medically recovered and feeling completely fearless are not always the same thing. A player returning from injury may hesitate during:

- contact
- sprinting
- cutting
- jumping
- tackling
- striking the ball
- repeating the movement associated with the injury

That does not necessarily mean she lacks courage. Feeling nervous and excited at the same time is common. Confidence may need to be rebuilt through successful repetitions. The coach should allow the player to regain trust in her body without constantly drawing attention to the injury. If fear is not fading after she is cleared, she should tell a parent so her provider knows.

Return progressively

The return should move from controlled situations toward full competition as appropriate.

A typical path, set with her health care provider: controlled work on her own → team drills without contact → full training → short game minutes → full games. She moves up when she handles each step well, not just because a date arrives. If pain or swelling comes back, she steps back and her family checks with her provider. Stepping back is part of the process, not a failure. Short minutes at first are part of the plan, not a judgment. After a serious knee injury, such as a torn ACL, returning to cutting and pivoting sports like soccer often takes a year or more, and her medical team sets the timeline. The chance of another ACL injury is highest in the first year after surgery, so waiting until she is truly ready is the tough choice.

A player may need to rebuild:

- movement confidence
- timing
- fitness
- ball comfort
- decision speed
- contact confidence
- trust in the injured area

The goal is not simply “Can she survive a game?” The better question is “Can she play freely and confidently again?”

Do not be afraid of the game

Once a player has appropriately recovered and is cleared to return, we want her gradually to trust herself again. We do not want the injury to permanently teach fear. The player should eventually be able to think: “I am prepared. I am strong. I can play normally again.” The team and coach should help reinforce that confidence. Do not constantly remind the returning player that she was injured. Do not treat her as fragile once she is ready. Support her return to being an athlete.

Teammates should respect the return process

Do not question why a teammate is still out. Do not tell her she should be playing. Do not tease her about being injured. Do not compare recovery times. Do not assume that because two injuries sound similar, their recovery should be the same. Do not pass on details or guesses about her injury, in person or online. Instead:

Support. Encourage. Welcome her back.

Coaches should never reward hidden injuries

A player who plays through something she should have reported should not become the model of toughness for the team. We want players to trust that they can tell us when something is wrong. That trust protects athletes. **Telling us early is never held against you.** Sitting out while you are hurt is not a punishment. Coaches thank a player for speaking up, every time. Parents: say the same thing at home.

When a player returns

Welcome her back normally. Do not make the first mistake, missed tackle, lost sprint, or moment of hesitation into evidence that she came back too soon. She may need time to regain rhythm. Encourage her to focus on the same principles she used before the injury: the practice mantra (**SCAN. TALK. INTENTION. FASTER.**) and the game mantra (**CALM MIND. FAST SOCCER.**). And when the first difficult physical moment arrives:

WANT THE MOMENT.

Not because she should ignore fear or pain, but because once she is healthy, cleared, and ready, that moment is part of rebuilding confidence.

The team standard

We care about our teammates when they are playing. We care about them when they are injured. We care about them while they recover. And we care enough about them not to rush them back.

Health first. Stay connected. Recover completely. Return confidently.

Communication & Movement Fundamentals

Shared language makes the team faster because nobody has to guess what a teammate means. The goal is not constant shouting. Communication should be early, specific, useful, and positive.

Communication glossary

Information cues

These give the player information rather than making the decision for her.

- **Time** — you have room to control and look up.
- **Man on** — pressure is arriving immediately.
- **Turn** — you can receive and face forward.
- **Left shoulder / right shoulder** — check that side now.
- **Inside / outside** — where the pressure, support, or space is (for example, support is available inside).
- **Cover** — I am behind or inside you as support.
- **Line** — option down the touchline.

Action cues

These suggest a useful action, but the player who hears the cue still owns the final decision.

- **Set** — bounce or lay the ball back quickly.
- **Hold** — keep possession; do not force the ball forward.
- **Drop** — recover or offer a deeper support option.
- **Step** — close or intercept now.
- **Delay** — buy time; do not dive in.
- **Leave** — let the ball run to another player.

Big-space cues

These tell the team that the field has opened. Anyone can call them, but the player on the ball still owns the final decision.

- **Expand** — we have escaped pressure; use the larger space now.
- **Switch** — change the point of attack to the weak side (the side away from the ball).
- **Carry** — open grass is available; attack it with the ball.
- **Go** — an immediate transition or breakaway opportunity exists.

Over time, prefer useful information over remote-control commands.

Changing the size of the game

Recognize whether the soccer problem in front of you is a small-space problem or a large-space problem.

For a small-space problem, use:

- quick support
- short combinations
- third-player actions ($A \rightarrow B \rightarrow C$)
- wall passes
- tight receiving
- deception

For a large-space problem, use:

- carrying
- longer passing
- switches
- running beyond
- weak-side movement
- acceleration into open grass

When we escape pressure, the problem has changed — that is the moment to call **Expand** and use the bigger space.

SMALL SPACE: COMBINE. BIG SPACE: EXPLOIT.

Receiving posture

Scan while the ball travels

The best time to look away is when nothing new can happen to the ball, such as while it travels between teammates.

- Look early to build the picture.
- Look again just before the ball arrives.
- Look again after your first touch.

Quick looks are enough. You do not need to stare.

Look for three things: your open teammate, the nearest opponent, and the space. At least one look before receiving whenever there is time; more looks are not automatically better.

Side-on when possible

Open your hips enough to see both where the ball came from and where the next action may go.

Do not force an exaggerated side-on position if pressure or the pass angle makes another posture safer.

Meet the ball

Do not wait flat-footed for a pass that a defender can attack.

Step toward the pass when appropriate and arrive before the defender.

Meet the ball applies to:

- checking to feet
- midfield receiving
- defenders intercepting
- attacking crosses and loose balls

First touch begins the next action

A good first touch is not simply stopping the ball.

Use the arriving ball to:

- turn
- escape pressure
- carry
- protect
- set up the next pass

Your first touch can beat a defender.

A touch past or away from an arriving defender can take her out of the play before you pass or dribble.

The pass tells the receiver which way to turn. Receiving under pressure is a skill to develop, not a situation to avoid.

Athletic posture

General principles:

- knees soft
- weight balanced
- feet alive
- not tall and locked
- ready to move in more than one direction

1v1 defensive posture

Approach fast, arrive controlled

Close space quickly, then shorten the final steps so the attacker cannot beat you with one touch.

Low, wide, and mobile

As you arrive, break down: feet a little wider than shoulder-width, knees bent, weight on the balls of your feet.

Get low and wide enough to move side to side, but do not sink so low that movement becomes slow.

Avoid unnecessary crossing of the feet

Use controlled side-to-side and crossover steps, depending on the attacker's distance and speed.

Show rather than dive

Use your body angle to influence the attacker toward less dangerous space.

Delay when she has the advantage

Protect → slow → show → wait → win. Stay between her and goal, take away her speed, steer her away from danger, stay balanced, and win the ball when the moment comes. An excellent delay may contain no tackle. See [Coaching Game Model §21](#).

Pursuit angles

When you are recovering, do not simply chase the attacker's back.

Do not run to where the attacker is. Run to where she is going.

Aim first toward the dangerous lane between the attacker and goal, then curve your recovery run as the gap closes.

This helps you:

- cut off central space
- shorten the route to goal
- force the attacker wider
- recover without needing to win a pure footrace from behind

Movement timing

Move on the pass. Move again after you pass.

Move on the pass

Anticipate the next picture while the ball is traveling. Start moving as the pass is played, not after it arrives.

Move again after you pass

After every pass, ask:

Where can I help next?

Arrive, don't camp

If you get to a useful space too early, defenders can settle and block the lane.

Move into the space as the passing lane develops.

Different heights

Avoid standing in a flat line with nearby teammates when possible.

Staggering — some of you higher up the field, some deeper — creates angles and third-player options.

Defensive vision

Gather information about:

- ball
- goal
- teammates
- opponents
- dangerous space

See the ball and the most dangerous space or opponent. Do not become so focused on a single mark that you lose the larger picture.

Protect dangerous space first. Get tighter as the ball and danger get closer.

Get compact first, then pick up the dangerous opponent in your part of the field. Get tight on restarts (free kicks, corners, and throw-ins), on crosses, and when you step to win the ball.

Transition posture

Good defensive positioning should help the next attack.

Good attacking positioning should help the next defensive transition.

Defend from a position you can attack from.

Final standard

Good movement should make teammates' decisions easier.

Create an angle. Meet the ball. Stay balanced. Move again.

Film Review Guide

IN THIS CHAPTER

The most important rule	26	Simple game tally	29
Review sequence	26	Watch the next developmental level	30
Questions to ask	27	What to compare across levels	30
Watch away from the ball	28	Position study	31
Review one theme at a time	28	Sharing film safely	32
Three-part self-review	29	Final principle	32

The purpose of film study is not to decide whether you “played well.” It is to learn how to see the game more clearly and become your own coach.

The most important rule

Pause before you know the outcome.

If you wait until after the play ends, it is too easy to judge the decision only by what happened.

A good decision can fail because of execution. A poor decision can succeed because of luck.

Even professionals get fooled. In one study, shots that hit the post and went in earned players better ratings than similar shots that hit the post and stayed out.

Judge the choice, not the bounce.

Review sequence

For each useful clip:

- 1. Pause before the action.**
- 2. Scan the picture.** What information should the player know?
- 3. List the realistic options.** Try to find more than one.
- 4. Play each option forward 2–4 actions.** What might happen next?
- 5. Find one non-obvious option.** Could deception or creativity change the picture?
- 6. Choose.** Commit to the option you would pick before you press play.
- 7. Watch the play.** What actually happened?
- 8. Judge decision and execution separately.**
- 9. Write down one useful lesson.**

Questions to ask

Without the ball

- If I did not touch the ball, could I still have influenced the play?
- Did my position create an option, pull a defender, or protect dangerous space?

Before receiving

- Did I scan early enough?
- Where was pressure coming from?
- Where was my best support?
- Was there open space I could have carried into?
- What did my body shape allow me to see?

In possession

- Did I recognize the best advantage?
- Did I pass simply because someone was close?
- Could I have carried farther?
- Was a switch available?
- Could I have fixed a defender first?
- Did my pass help the receiver's next action?
- Could deception have created a better option?

After passing

- Did I move again?
- Did I become another outlet?
- Did I create space for someone else?
- Did I prepare for a possible turnover?

Defending

- Did I protect the most dangerous space?
- Could I see the ball and the dangerous opponent or space?
- Who pressured the ball, and who covered her?
- Did I step, delay, cover, or recover appropriately?
- Could I have intercepted instead of simply following my player?
- If recovering, did I use a good pursuit angle or simply chase from behind?
- If we could not win it immediately, did we get compact and protect the middle?

Transition

After losing it:

- Could we counterpress?
- If not, did I recover immediately?
- Was I already in a useful rest-defense position (placed to stop a counterattack while we still had the ball)?

After winning it:

- Did I scan forward first?
- Was there a real breakaway opportunity?
- If not, did we secure possession?

Team shape

- Did we form triangles, or stand in flat lines?
- Who gave width? Who gave depth?
- Did players move before the pass, or only after it?
- Was there a backward option, and could it have opened something forward?
- When nothing good was on, did we keep the ball?
- When was dribbling better than passing?

Watch away from the ball

Some of the most important learning happens where the ball is not.

Pick a player and watch only her for 5–10 minutes.

Notice:

- how often she scans
- when she moves before the pass
- how she creates angles
- when she stays wide or moves inside
- how she reacts after passing
- what she does on the weak side
- how she prepares for transitions
- how much she influences play without touching the ball

Review one theme at a time

Do not try to analyze an entire game at once.

Choose 6–10 useful clips around one theme.

New to film study? Start with these themes, in this order:

1. scanning and awareness
2. first touch
3. supporting the player on the ball
4. receiving and playing through pressure
5. off-ball movement
6. defending and defensive positioning

Then add themes such as:

- carrying into space
- switching play
- pursuit angles
- transition reaction
- deception
- weak-side behavior

If the same problem shows up game after game, make it your theme. A recurring problem is worth noticing, especially if practice is not addressing it yet. Work on your part of it at home, and bring it to the coach as a question (“What should I be looking for here?”), not a complaint.

Three-part self-review

After a game, identify:

One thing I did well

Something to continue and strengthen.

One thing I need to improve

A specific behavior, not a vague judgment.

Bring your one thing to improve to the next team film share at practice, where each player names one thing from her own game.

One solution I want to try

A concrete action for the next practice or game.

Take your one solution into the next practice, then look for it again on the next film.

Film trains what you look for. Practice and games turn it into speed.

Simple game tally

From one half of film, count:

- times I received the ball
- receptions with at least one scan first (a head turn away from the ball in the 5 seconds before the first touch)
- receptions facing forward or on the half-turn (side-on, so you can see forward and back)
- passes or carries that broke a line (got the ball past a line of opponents)
- times I moved to a new angle after passing
- times I won or blocked the ball by reading the play
- times I asked for the ball

Skip clips where you cannot clearly see the head. Far-away team-camera video often cannot show it. You often cannot hear calls on it either, so count only the asks for the ball you can see (pointing, showing for it) or hear.

Compare scanning like with like. Everyone scans less under tight pressure, near the touchline, and near goal. Center midfielders (the pivots and the 10) usually scan the most and forwards the least, so compare your own clips from the same position and situation.

Compare with your own last game, not with teammates.

Record your tally and your three-part self-review on the [Game Reflection](#) sheet.

Watch the next developmental level

Professional matches are useful, but also watch soccer just 2–3 years above your age group. It shows what players only a little older are expected to do. For U13–U14, start with U15–U16.

Starting in 2026–27, ECNL, ECNL RL, Girls Academy, and most U.S. youth leagues group players by **school year (Aug 1–Jul 31)**, not birth year. League events use U-ages, so search by U-age:

- “ECNL girls U16 full match”
- “ECNL RL girls U16 full match”
- “ECNL girls national playoffs U16”
- “Girls Academy National Finals U16”
- a strong club name plus “U16 girls”

Swap “U16” for “U15” in any of these searches.

Be careful with birth-year titles. A “2010” video from 2025–26 shows U16 players. Today the same label can mean U16 or U17 players. Add the season (for example “2025-26”) when you search by birth year.

Where to find full games:

- **ECNLTV** (paid; ECNL and ECNL RL games, plus national playoffs with replays)
- **Girls Academy on YouTube** (National Finals livestreams)
- club channels that post their own full games

Services change every season. Check each league’s website first. Links are in [Sources and Further Reading](#).

Prefer **full matches**, not highlights.

Highlights teach moments. Full matches teach soccer.

What to compare across levels

Compare four levels using the same questions:

1. our match
2. a good U15–U16 ECNL RL match
3. a top U15–U16 ECNL match
4. a professional women’s match

Ask:

- How quickly do players reposition after passing?
- How often do they scan before receiving?
- How fast does the ball move without becoming rushed?
- How often do they carry open space?
- How often do they switch fields intentionally?
- What do weak-side players do?
- What happens immediately after possession changes?
- How often are defenders forced to make decisions by movement or deception?
- Freeze the video at a random moment. Can you see evidence of coaching without hearing the coach?

The freeze test measures learning, not results: a team can lose and still show clear evidence of coaching, and win without much of it. For more, see [What Good Coaching Looks Like](#).

Full professional women's matches (U.S., 2026–27):

- **NWSL:** TV and streaming partners, plus free games on NWSL+
- **WSL (England):** Paramount+

TV and streaming rights change often. Check the league's "How to Watch" page.

Position study

When preparing for a role, watch one strong player in that position and ignore the ball whenever she does not have it.

Ask:

- Where does she stand when the ball is on the opposite side?
- How does she create an outlet?
- What does she do after passing?
- When does she step, drop, press, or delay?
- What does she do immediately when possession changes?

One question for your position

When you review your own game, start with the question for your position. Your position card helps you picture these moments before the game; this question checks them afterward.

- **Goalkeeper (#1):** After I collected the ball, did I scan and restart possession quickly, or punt by habit?
- **Outside back (#2 / #3):** When we lost it, did I recover on an angle to where the attacker was going, or chase from behind?
- **Center back (#4 / #5):** When nobody pressured me, did I carry or find midfield feet, or did I clear it?
- **Pivot (#6 / #8):** Before I received, did I know where the pressure was, and was I at a different height from my partner?

- **Winger (#7 / #11):** When the ball was on the far side, was I preparing for the switch, or just watching?
- **Striker (#9):** Did my movement change what the center backs had to decide?
- **Attacking midfielder (#10):** Did I find space between the lines, and did I move again after I passed?

Sharing film safely

Team film stays with the team.

- Watch game film through the team's private link or app. Do not repost it publicly.
- Clips of a teammate are for learning. Describe, don't judge. Never share a teammate's mistake in a group chat, story, or comment.
- Questions about your film go to the coach through the team app, with a parent included.
- If a family asks for a clip of their daughter to come down, it comes down.
- No recording in locker rooms, restrooms, or changing areas. When watching other teams online, learn from them; don't repost or comment on their players.

Final principle

Film review is not about proving that a player was right or wrong.

It is about building a better mental picture of the game.

See more. Understand more. Choose better.

Home Development Menu

IN THIS CHAPTER

1 Wall work: primary first-touch training	33	9 Strength basics: calves, hips, hamstrings, trunk ...	37
2 Juggling	34	10 Acceleration and change of direction	37
3 Triangle-cone dribbling	34	11 Film study counts as development	37
4 Small-space keep-away	35	12 Mental reps	38
5 Passing and longer ball work	35	Sample short sessions	38
6 Weak-foot minimum	35	Recovery basics	38
7 Jump rope	36	Final principle	39
8 Low-level plyometrics	36		

Home work should make a player **more capable, not more tired**.

This is an optional menu, not a requirement to complete everything. In a heavy team week, recovery may be the best choice.

A useful approach is to choose 2–3 short items and work with quality.

Use the menu to fill gaps. If your role or your team's training gives you few reps at something, such as turning under pressure or longer passing, make that one of your picks.

Count the whole week.

Team practices, games, other sports, and structured training sessions all add up. The National Athletic Trainers' Association recommends:

- no more hours of organized sport per week (all sports together) than your age in years
- at least two days a week free of organized training and games

Going over that is a warning sign. Relaxed free play (juggling, pickup, kicking around) is different from adding another hard session.

Rest is part of the plan.

- On at least 1–2 of your days free of organized training, skip soccer completely: no home menu, juggling, or pickup. Other active play is fine.
- Build real breaks from soccer into the year.

1. Wall work: primary first-touch training

Wall work is our main first-touch training because the ball comes back with pace.

Useful patterns

- firm pass → receive across your body → play with the opposite foot
- one-touch set → move to a new angle → receive again
- weak-foot receiving and passing
- first touch away from pressure
- first touch into a carry
- one-touch and two-touch combinations
- vary the distance to change the return speed
- put two cone gates behind you and choose an exit before the ball returns

Add a look. On some reps, check a shoulder while the ball travels to the wall. A partner behind you can hold up fingers or point to a gate. Receive toward that exit.

Pure reps build technique. Reps with a look and a choice are closer to the game. Use both.

Juggling helps build touch. Receiving develops usable touch.

A good first touch is not stopping the ball. It is using the arriving ball to begin the next action.

2. Juggling

Juggling is useful for:

- coordination
- comfort with different surfaces
- foot-eye control
- weak-foot familiarity
- general ball mastery

Use it as a supplement rather than the only touch work.

3. Triangle-cone dribbling

Place three cones in a triangle.

Work around them with:

- inside and outside touches
- sole pulls
- V-cuts
- drag-pushes
- Cruyff turns
- L-turns
- changes of speed
- weak-foot actions
- improvised moves

Do not repeat only one pattern.

Add the team deception principle:

Look like you're changing your mind.

The goal is speed plus creativity.

4. Small-space keep-away

With a parent, sibling, or friend:

- use a small box
- protect the ball
- use changes of direction
- shield
- escape pressure
- use deception

Even a short 1v1 keep-away session adds decision-making that cone work cannot provide.

Keep-away is a game skill, not just a drill. You do not need to be a flashy dribbler. In a game, when nobody is open forward, think:

I can protect it, turn away, carry sideways, or go backward, and keep it.

Pickup counts. Keep-away, futsal, and small games with friends build reading and decision-making. Play for fun adds to team training; it does not replace it.

5. Passing and longer ball work

Get comfortable with more than short rondo distances. In games, when we escape pressure and the field opens, the problem has changed: a longer pass into space can be the best solution.

When space allows, practice:

- firm 10–20 yard ground passes
- longer driven ground passes (20–40 yards)
- diagonals
- receiving a longer pass while moving
- controlling the ball into the next action

The goal is intentional range, not simply kicking far. A longer pass with a clear purpose is not a clearance.

Purposeful distance, not hopeful distance.

6. Weak-foot minimum

Every technical session should include some weak-foot work:

- passing
- receiving
- carrying
- turning
- finishing when appropriate

Weak-foot work does not cost your strong foot. In one study, players who trained only their weak foot for 8 weeks improved both feet.

Even men's World Cup players rarely use their weaker foot. The goal is a real option when the picture calls for it.

7. Jump rope

Useful for:

- rhythm
- lower-leg coordination
- springy, reactive ankles
- general foot activity

Keep it short and crisp. It counts as jumping, so the “How much” and “Pain rule” guidance in section 8 applies to it too.

8. Low-level plyometrics

Plyometrics are quick, springy jumps and hops that train your legs to push off and land well.

Examples:

- pogo jumps
- line hops
- snap-downs
- controlled two-leg jumps
- low-volume single-leg hops when technique is sound

Priorities

- **Land soft and quiet.** Stick the landing before the next jump.
- **Knees stay in line over the toes.** Don't let them cave in.
- On cuts: plant, sink the hips, push off with the knee over the foot.
- Quality over quantity.

How much

Count good reps, not minutes.

- A few short sets of crisp reps per drill, with full rest between sets.
- Jump first in the session, while fresh.
- Stop when landings get loud or knees cave in.
- Learn a drill at team training before doing it at home.
- Jump rope counts as jumping. In a heavy team week, jumping is the first thing to cut.

Pain rule

Heel pain, or pain at the bump just below the kneecap, is common in growing players.

- If it hurts during or after jumping, skip jump rope and hops for now and choose ball work instead.
- Jump on grass or turf, not concrete, in well-cushioned shoes.
- Tell a parent and your coach.
- A limp, or pain that is making soccer no fun, means see a doctor.

For any pain or injury beyond this kind of growth pain, tell a parent and your coach, and see [Injuries, Recovery, and Return to Play](#).

Growing bodies

Same age, different body age. Girls usually grow fastest around 11–12, but anywhere from about 9 to 15 is normal. Some temporary clumsiness during a growth spurt is normal; keep training landing, balance, and strength, which do the most for knees at this age. Don't mistake early size for talent, or late growth for a lack of it.

9. Strength basics: calves, hips, hamstrings, trunk

Examples:

- straight- and bent-knee calf raises, then single-leg raises and holds near the top
- squats and lunges (knees in line over the toes)
- single-leg balance and slow single-leg squats
- front and side planks
- partner Nordic hamstrings at the FIFA 11+ beginner level, only after learning them at team training

1–3 sets of 6–15 controlled reps (far fewer for Nordics), 2–3 times a week, not on back-to-back days. Our injury-prevention warm-up (FIFA 11+ or a similar program) uses many of these same exercises, so warm-up days count toward your 2–3 strength days. In teenage girls, programs like this cut ACL injuries by roughly half, but only when every exercise is done correctly.

Technique first, then add reps. Stop the set when form breaks down.

10. Acceleration and change of direction

Short, high-quality work is enough.

Examples:

- 5–10 yard accelerations
- lateral starts
- crossover starts
- reaction starts
- short planned cuts
- short reactive cuts with a partner cue

On every cut, use the priorities in section 8. If heel or knee pain shows up, the pain rule in section 8 applies to sprints too.

Real agility involves reacting to information. Ladders can help rhythm and coordination, but should not be treated as the main agility method.

11. Film study counts as development

Ten focused minutes of film can be more useful than adding another hard physical session.

Use the [Film Review Guide](#).

12. Mental reps

3–5 minutes, especially the day before a game:

- picture your role in the four moments
- rehearse your response after a mistake: your **team reset**, then next play
- pick one cue from your **position card**

Mental reps add to real practice. **They do not replace it.**

Sample short sessions

Technical 15 minutes

- 7 min wall work
- 5 min triangle dribbling
- 3 min juggling or weak foot

Athletic 12 minutes

- jump rope in a few short, crisp sets with rest (about 3 min)
- 2–3 short sets of pogos or line hops, full rest
- 3 min strength basics
- 3 min short acceleration or movement quality

Mixed 20 minutes

- about 4 min jumping and coordination: a few short sets of jump rope, or 2–3 short sets of hops, full rest
- 8 min wall work
- 5 min dribbling
- 3 min film or visualization

For visualization, replay one receiving moment from your last game in your head: check both shoulders, spot the pressure and the space, choose your touch. Then replay it again with a better choice.

Recovery basics

Sleep is training. Aim for 8–10 hours. Teen athletes who usually sleep less than 8 hours get injured more often. When time is short, sleep beats an extra session.

Fuel the work. Eat enough for your training, including iron, calcium, and vitamin D. Once periods have started, going about 3 months or more without one, or no period by age 15, is not a normal part of hard training: tell a parent and see a doctor. See **Parent Partnership: Health signals**.

Rest days and weekly hours are covered at the start of this menu (“Count the whole week” and “Rest is part of the plan”).

Parents: fueling, health signals, and how to help at home are covered in **Parent Partnership**.

Final principle

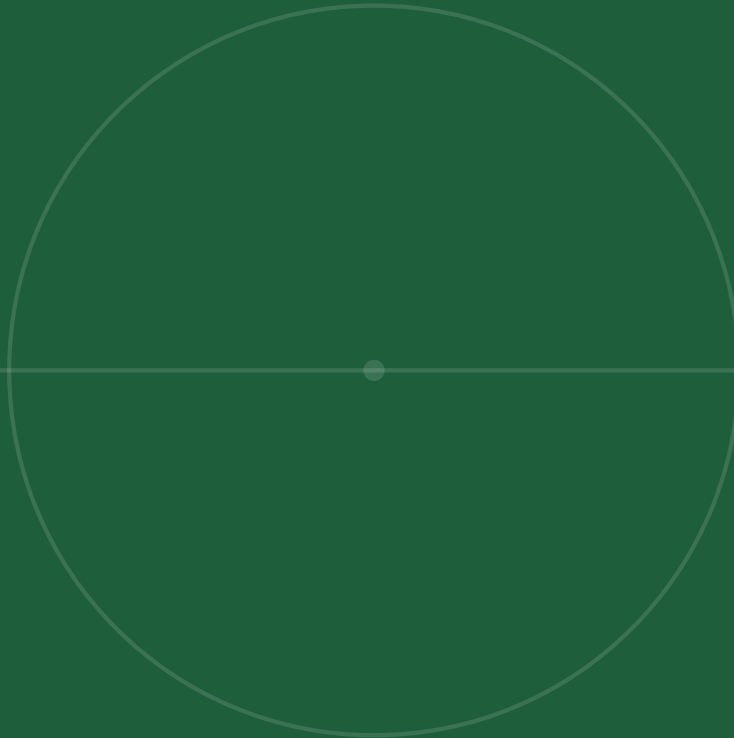
Extra work should sharpen skills and confidence without undermining team training, school, sleep, or recovery.

Short, focused, high-quality work beats tired volume.

PART TWO

Position Cards

One-page pregame preparation and visualization cards to review before every match. The right side takes the lower number.



Goalkeeper #1

MY PURPOSE

Protect the goal, organize the team in front of you, and be our eleventh possession player.

PREGAME MINDSET

Calm and decisive.

If you decide to come, come. If you decide to play, play. You don't need to save everything or pass perfectly — make the next decision completely. Talk early, before danger develops; your voice leads the team. After a mistake or a goal, get set and organize right away:

RESPOND. REFLECT. LEARN. NEXT PLAY.

WHEN YOU'RE UNSURE

**Get set. Communicate.
Make the next decision fully.**

PICTURE THESE MOMENTS

- Picture a back pass rolling to you: you open your body, touch it across, and play to the opposite side.
- Picture a center back under pressure: you move to an angle behind her and call early for the pass back.
- Picture catching the ball, scanning right away, and throwing or rolling it to an open teammate before the other team resets.
- Picture a through ball behind the back line: you decide to come, and come all the way to sweep it.
- Picture a cross coming in: you decide early, call it loudly, and claim it — or punch it clear.
- Picture getting set for a shot, then getting back up and organizing the team, whatever happened.

WHEN WE HAVE IT

- Back passes are normal soccer, not emergencies. Use both feet.
- Read the press before the goal kick: short if they leave space, beyond them if they commit everyone.
- Distribute with intention. Punt or go long when it is truly better, not by habit.

WHEN WE LOSE IT

- Reorganize quickly behind the ball and communicate depth, runners, and danger.
- When our line is high, start higher too, so you can sweep behind it.

WHEN THEY HAVE IT

- Manage your depth relative to the back line.
- Point out runners your back line cannot see.

WHEN WE WIN IT

- Scan right away: can we restart possession quickly and intelligently?
- Ball in your hands? Release it within 8 seconds, or they get a corner kick.

Quick possession before hopeful distance.

IMPORTANT RELATIONSHIPS

- Center backs (#4 / #5): be their outlet and extra eyes — tell them early to step, drop, or play back to you.
- Outside backs (#2 / #3) and pivots (#6 / #8): a quick throw or pass to a free one can beat the press.

MY CUES

**Organize. Decide.
Commit. Distribute.**

These are principles, not restrictions. If you recognize a better solution, take it.

Outside Back #2 / #3

MY PURPOSE

Protect the outside channel, give the team a wide outlet, and join the attack without losing defensive balance.

PREGAME MINDSET

Be proactive going forward and relentless recovering.

Getting forward is not a mistake when it is intelligent and you recover the moment we lose the ball. Read your winger, talk to her, and take the space she is not using.

WHEN YOU'RE UNSURE

Protect inside first.

PICTURE THESE MOMENTS

- Picture a center back under pressure: you move wide early, open your body, and give her an easy outlet.
- Picture receiving with open grass ahead: you carry until a defender has to step, then release the winger or the 9.
- Picture a wall pass with your winger: you pass, run past your defender, and get it back.
- Picture your winger on the ball: if she cuts inside, you overlap to give width; if she stays wide, you underlap or support underneath.
- Picture losing the ball high: you sprint back on an angle to where the attacker is going, not behind her.
- Picture the ball on the far side: you tuck toward the center backs, spot the far-post runner, and get there first.

WHEN WE HAVE IT

- Play inside, backward, or switch when down the line is closed — don't force it.
- Overlap when it creates something, not by habit.

WHEN WE LOSE IT

- React immediately: counterpress with support if the ball is near and recoverable.
- Otherwise sprint back: cut off the dangerous route to goal first, then curve the run.

**Do not run to where the attacker is.
Run to where she is going.**

WHEN THEY HAVE IT

- Protect inside danger first: see the ball and the most dangerous opponent or space.
- Know when to step, delay, or cover.
- Don't get dragged so wide or high that the center becomes exposed.
- Far side: stay connected to your center back; expand again when we win it.

WHEN WE WIN IT

- Look for a quick transition if the space is real.
- Otherwise become a safe outlet and help us secure possession.

IMPORTANT RELATIONSHIPS

- Your winger (#7 / #11): don't share a lane. If she comes inside, give width. If she stays wide, support underneath.
- Nearest center back (#4 / #5): stay connected to her line, and talk to her.
- The other outside back (#2 / #3): don't both go high unless the pivots (#6 / #8) stay underneath.

MY CUES

**Angle. Support. Carry.
Protect. Recover.**

These are principles, not restrictions. If you recognize a better solution, take it.

Center Back #4 / #5

MY PURPOSE

Protect the center, lead the back line, and start our attacks with composure.

PREGAME MINDSET

Calm is a weapon.

Safe does not automatically mean clearance. Near your own goal, if you have time and space, solve the soccer problem — even after a pass goes wrong. Talk early: tell the line to step, drop, or cover. **CALM MIND. FAST SOCCER.**

WHEN YOU'RE UNSURE

Protect the center.
Stay balanced. Buy the team time.

PICTURE THESE MOMENTS

- Picture receiving from the goalkeeper: you check your shoulder, open your body, and touch it forward.
- Picture nobody pressing you: you carry until a defender steps, then find the midfielder she left.
- Picture the ball side getting crowded: you switch it to the open side.
- Picture their press pushing high and a far-side winger free: you hit a purposeful diagonal into her path.
- Picture an attacker running at you on a counter: you stay on your feet, slow her down, and wait for help.
- Picture your partner stepping to win the ball: you tuck in behind her and cover the space she left.

WHEN WE HAVE IT

- Your partner is an option, not an automatic pass.
- Carry sideways to change the angle when the forward lane is closed.
- Find midfield feet when the lane is real; after you pass, step up to support.

WHEN WE LOSE IT

- Protect the central route to goal first, then step, delay, or recover.
- If an outside back is caught high, delay the counter until she recovers.
- Recover on an angle toward goal, not by chasing.

WHEN THEY HAVE IT

- Ball pressured: hold the line or push up together.
- Ball unpressured: drop a few steps together — moving as one line manages offside.
- Crosses: stay goal-side, see ball and runner, attack the ball in front of you.
- Read the pass early; intercept when you can win it.

WHEN WE WIN IT

- Scan forward: if a real transition advantage exists, use it.
- If not, secure the ball and start possession calmly.

IMPORTANT RELATIONSHIPS

One steps, one covers.

- The other center back (#4 / #5): don't both go to the same attacker, and don't both leave her free.
- Pivots (#6 / #8): they give you an angle and protect the space in front of you. Delay counters together.
- Goalkeeper (#1): your outlet and your eyes behind you. Keep her available; listen to her calls.
- Outside backs (#2 / #3): use them as early wide outlets, and keep them connected to your line.

MY CUES

Calm. Talk. Carry. Connect. Delay.

These are principles, not restrictions. If you recognize a better solution, take it.

Defensive Midfielder / Pivot #6 / #8

MY PURPOSE

Connect the team, protect the space underneath the ball, and help control the tempo of the game.

PREGAME MINDSET

Want the ball.

Don't hide when an opponent is close. Scan, find a better angle, and trust yourself to solve the pressure. Not every touch must speed us up: go forward, switch, carry, or keep the ball while the team reorganizes.

CALM MIND. FAST SOCCER.

WHEN YOU'RE UNSURE

Become an angle. Protect underneath.

PICTURE THESE MOMENTS

- Picture a center back passing to you: you check both shoulders, open your body, and know your next pass.
- Picture the ball moving away from you: you slide to a new angle so the next passer can find you.
- Picture a defender closing from behind: your first touch escapes her, and you switch the ball to the open side.
- Picture your partner dropping deeper to help the center backs: you rise higher.
- Picture our outside backs pushed high: you stay underneath the attack, ready to win the ball the moment we lose it.
- Picture open grass in front of you and nobody stepping: you carry until a defender has to react.

WHEN WE HAVE IT

- Scan before receiving when there is time; receive side-on and move again after passing.
- Play forward when the advantage is real; recycle or switch when it is not.

WHEN WE LOSE IT

- Counterpress right away if the ball is close and someone protects underneath.
- Otherwise recover in front of the center backs.
- If an outside back is caught high, delay the counter until she recovers.

WHEN THEY HAVE IT

- Screen central passing lanes; step when the picture is covered, delay when exposed.
- Long ball from them: move to where it will land to win the second ball.
- Ball wide in our third: protect the top of the box and the cutback lane.

WHEN WE WIN IT

- Scan forward first: if an attacker is released into space, play quickly.
- If not, secure the first pass and help us organize.

IMPORTANT RELATIONSHIPS

One shows. One protects. One threatens.

- You, the other pivot (#6 / #8), and the 10 are a rotating triangle, not three fixed dots. Who does each job can change.
- If one drops, another rises. If one advances, another protects underneath. If the 10 moves, the triangle adjusts.
- Your partner: stay at different heights, keep talking, and never both leave the center.
- Center backs (#4 / #5): give them an angle, protect the space in front of them, and delay counters together.

MY CUES

Scan. Angle. Connect. Protect.

These are principles, not restrictions. If you recognize a better solution, take it.

Winger #7 / #11

MY PURPOSE

Stretch the defense, threaten behind, attack favorable 1v1s, and become dangerous inside when it's on.

PREGAME MINDSET

Be dangerous before you touch the ball.

Your position and runs should already make defenders uncomfortable.

Want the next 1v1. When a 1v1 favors you, attack it. If a dribble fails, notice why, change your move, and go again. **WANT THE MOMENT.**

WHEN YOU'RE UNSURE

**Create width or threaten depth.
Do not disappear.**

PICTURE THESE MOMENTS

- Picture receiving wide with one defender isolated in front of you: you attack her with speed and a change of direction.
- Picture the 9 checking toward the ball: you start wide and run diagonally into the space she left behind.
- Picture escaping pressure near the touchline, then carrying into open grass until a defender has to step.
- Picture winning the ball back: a central lane opens, and you become the central runner even though you started wide.
- Picture a switch arriving at your feet with space: your first touch goes forward before they can shift.
- Picture us attacking down the far side: you arrive at the far post just as the cross comes in.

WHEN WE HAVE IT

- Start wide, then run diagonally behind — not only straight down the touchline.
- Make crossing runs that force defenders to decide who follows you.
- Swap sides with the other winger when it creates an advantage, but keep our width.
- Use deception before you cross, dribble, or combine.

WHEN WE LOSE IT

- Lost it wide? Counterpress right away if a teammate is close enough to help.
- Otherwise recover into team shape and track the dangerous outside route.

WHEN THEY HAVE IT

- Know when to press their outside back or hold shape.
- Help protect central passing lanes, and see the ball and weak-side danger.
- Ball on the far side: tuck inside to keep midfield compact.

WHEN WE WIN IT

- Look immediately for open field to attack.
- If the transition is not on, give width and become a clean outlet.

IMPORTANT RELATIONSHIPS

- Outside back (#2 / #3): don't share a lane. If you go inside, she gives width. If you stay wide, she supports underneath.
- Striker (#9): when she checks, run diagonally behind. Swap lanes with her when it creates an advantage.
- In transition, whoever has the better lane takes the central run. Sometimes that is you, and the 9 supports.
- Attacking midfielder (#10): combine in the half-space, and rotate with her without losing our width.

MY CUES

Wide. Diagonal. Threaten. Arrive.

These are principles, not restrictions. If you recognize a better solution, take it.

Striker #9

MY PURPOSE

Occupy the center backs, stretch the defense, connect attacks, and finish chances.

PREGAME MINDSET

Be patient without disappearing.

Few touches can still shape a game through your runs, your pressing, and the center backs you keep busy. If a run isn't working, notice why and try a different one. **Want the next chance.** A missed shot should not change the courage of your next one: **RESPOND. REFLECT.**

LEARN. NEXT PLAY.

WHEN YOU'RE UNSURE

Threaten behind first. Then read what your movement creates.

PICTURE THESE MOMENTS

- Picture pinning a center back, checking short as the 10 runs beyond you, then getting back up high.
- Picture dragging your defender away so a winger can drive inside through the gap.
- Picture bending a diagonal run across a center back into the space behind her.
- Picture the ball wide near the end line: you attack near post, far post, or the cutback, then the second ball.
- Picture laying the ball off, then moving right away into the next space.
- Picture a faster winger breaking centrally in transition: you support her run instead of racing her.

WHEN WE HAVE IT

- Make diagonal runs behind, not just straight ones, so defenders can't step up freely.
- Check to the ball when it helps a combination or opens space behind.

WHEN WE LOSE IT

- React immediately: press if the ball is near you and teammates can support.
- Otherwise block passes into the middle and steer play toward our pressing plan.

WHEN THEY HAVE IT

- Stay connected and make their buildup predictable; don't chase every defender.
- Lead the press with your voice and a curved run that blocks a passing lane.

WHEN WE WIN IT

- Decide quickly: run behind, show to feet, or drag a defender away for a teammate.
- No advantage? Help us keep the ball.

IMPORTANT RELATIONSHIPS

One comes. One goes.

- Attacking midfielder (#10): if you check, she can run beyond you. If she checks, you stay high and pin the center backs.
- You and the 10 can keep cycling during an attack. Positions set the shape; movement changes who fills each space.
- Wingers (#7 / #11): when you check or move a center back, a winger can run diagonally into that space.
- Swap lanes when it helps. In transition, whoever has the better lane takes the central run.

MY CUES

Threaten. Move them. Finish.

These are principles, not restrictions. If you recognize a better solution, take it.

Attacking Midfielder #10

MY PURPOSE

Connect midfield to attack, find useful space between the lines, and help create chances.

PREGAME MINDSET

Want the ball in difficult spaces.

You are allowed to try the turn, the final pass, the dribble, or the combination. Some will not work. Don't let one failed idea make you cautious: **RESPOND. REFLECT. LEARN. NEXT PLAY.**

WHEN YOU'RE UNSURE

Find a different height than the 9 and become available.

PICTURE THESE MOMENTS

- Picture scanning, checking into a pocket between the lines, and receiving on the half-turn.
- Picture the 9 checking short: you run beyond her and become the highest attacker for now.
- Picture the 9 pinning both center backs while you show underneath her and turn.
- Picture drifting into the half-space — between wide and center — and playing a wall pass with a winger.
- Picture nobody stepping to you: you carry at the defense and sell a fake until someone has to choose.
- Picture helping deeper, then arriving at the top of the box in time for the cutback.

WHEN WE HAVE IT

One shows. One protects. One threatens.

- You and the pivots are a rotating triangle. Who does each job can change.
- Don't park: show between the lines, drop to connect, find a half-space, or run behind.
- Small space: combine. Big space: exploit. Carry, switch, or release a runner.

WHEN WE LOSE IT

- React immediately: you are often closest, so counterpress if support is near.
- Otherwise recover into midfield and protect central space.

WHEN THEY HAVE IT

- Know the plan: step up beside the 9, or screen their deepest midfielder.
- Stay connected to the pivots; screen passes into the middle.
- Recognize pressing triggers instead of chasing every pass.

WHEN WE WIN IT

- Look forward: release a runner or attack the middle before they recover.
- If not, help keep the ball while we reorganize.

IMPORTANT RELATIONSHIPS

One comes. One goes.

- Striker (#9): if she checks, you can run beyond her. If you check, she stays high and pins the center backs.
- You and the 9 can keep cycling during an attack. Positions set the shape; movement changes who fills each space.
- Pivots (#6 / #8): if you drop, one of them can rise. If one advances, another protects underneath.
- Wingers (#7 / #11): combine in the half-space and rotate without losing our width.

MY CUES

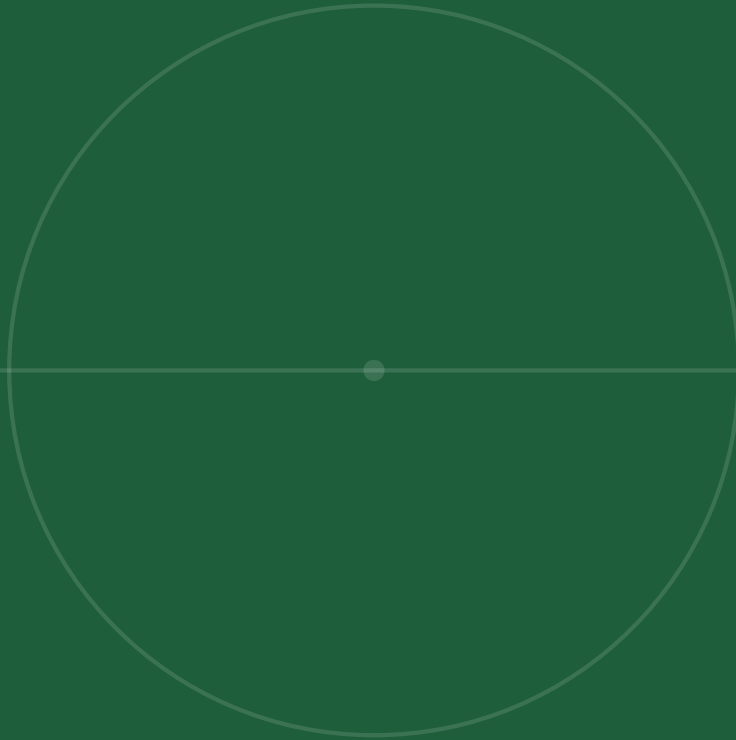
Scan. Find space. Connect. Arrive.

These are principles, not restrictions. If you recognize a better solution, take it.

PART THREE

For Coaches and Parents

The game model, the development system, and how families and coaches work together.



Coaching Game Model & Development Manual

IN THIS CHAPTER

1 Purpose	49	23 Compact defense and pressing	65
2 Core mantras	50	24 Restarts and set pieces	66
3 Competitive philosophy	52	25 Game state	67
4 Base structure	52	26 Individual 1v1 development	68
5 The four moments	53	27 Risk and emotional safety	68
6 Possession with purpose	54	28 Courage and responsibility	69
7 Possession at multiple scales — the middle gear	55	29 Position rotation	71
8 Carrying through space	57	30 Advance role preparation	72
9 Fixing defenders	58	31 Individual development plans	72
10 Deception	58	32 Player ownership and peer learning	73
11 Third-player soccer	58	33 Team development culture	74
12 Pass and move	59	34 Technical practice detail	74
13 Everyone is an outlet	59	35 Maximum meaningful ball interaction	75
14 Five-lane spacing	59	36 Athletic development	76
15 Weak-side behavior	59	37 Heading and head injuries	77
16 Front-line rotations	60	38 Safety basics	79
17 Outside back development	61	39 Film study	79
18 Building from the back	62	40 Practice design should respond to games	80
19 Goalkeeper in possession	63	41 Game-based learning and constraints	81
20 Rest defense	64	42 Create advantages	82
21 Delay defending	64	43 Coach communication	82
22 Off-ball defensive positioning	64	44 Communication, availability, and safeguarding ...	83
		45 Team identity	84

1. Purpose

The goal is to develop intelligent, technical, courageous players who can solve soccer problems themselves.

The team should be a vehicle for developing complete players, not merely a mechanism for winning the next match.

We are a committed, technical team without dominant athletes. We will not win a constant sprint race.

We win through spacing, information, combinations, possession, defensive organization, and collective decisions.

This document is for coaches. Players are **not** expected to consciously remember every item during games. The detailed principles here should be taught through representative training and reduced to simple cues for players.

Where to start

Do not try to install 45 sections at once. Build in layers, and move on when the previous layer is showing up consistently in games with fewer reminders:

1. **Culture and the four moments** (§2–5, §27–33): mantras, mistake culture, courage, and the habit of reacting the instant the ball changes hands.
2. **Spacing and outlets** (§12–15, §18–19): everyone becomes an option, pass and move, five lanes, building from the back with the goalkeeper.
3. **The middle gear** (§6–8): recognizing when pressure is escaped and the field is big, carrying, switching, purposeful longer passing.
4. **Defensive coordination** (§20–26): rest defense, delay, marking distance, pressing together, restarts, game state.
5. **Rotations and advanced detail** (§9–11, §16–17): fixing defenders, deception, third-player runs, front-line and outside-back movement.

Practice design (§40–41) and the development system (§29–31) run throughout.

The coaching system itself is a living system. We should be attached to good principles, not rigidly attached to one method.

Regularly ask:

- What is improving?
- What keeps appearing as a problem in games?
- Are practices transferring to matches?
- Are players understanding principles or merely following instructions?
- Has a player's development changed what role best suits her?
- Is one of our rules now limiting creativity rather than helping it?
- Is this environment making each player better, or only helping us win this weekend?
- What are players getting lots of reps at, and what are they getting almost none of?
- Could someone freeze our game at a random moment and see evidence of coaching?

For the signs to look for, see [What Good Coaching Looks Like](#).

2. Core mantras

Four mantras carry the whole model. Players know them by memory; the rest of this manual explains what they mean on the field.

Say it, then use it. Players say the practice mantra together, out loud, as the first thing at every practice, and the game mantra as the first thing in every game warm-up. It takes under 30 seconds. Coaches use the same words as live cues and in feedback. Now and then, ask a player for a quick example of one word from the last game.

Practice

SCAN. TALK. INTENTION. FASTER.

Practice is where we deliberately raise the speed at which good soccer survives.

Faster means:

- scan sooner
- communicate sooner
- move sooner
- pass more firmly
- support more quickly
- recover immediately
- make decisions under greater pressure
- reduce dead time and going through the motions

It does not mean panic.

A useful practice question is: **Are we actually playing faster, or are we just rushing?**

Games

CALM MIND. FAST SOCCER.

The emotional message reverses on game day. Players trust the speed developed in training and avoid manufacturing speed through panic.

When first teaching the game mantra, use the full version: “Calm mind. Fast soccer. See it before you get it.” Once the idea sticks, the first four words are enough.

Calm means clear attention, not low energy. Fast soccer is not getting rid of the ball quickly: it can mean holding the ball an extra second because she already scanned, playing backward, or carrying 15 yards because nobody stepped. Never tell a player to “calm down” before a pressure moment (see §28 for better language).

After mistakes

RESPOND. REFLECT. LEARN. NEXT PLAY.

Mistakes from intelligent risk-taking are expected. Coaches should distinguish decision quality from execution quality and never create shame around brave, thoughtful attempts.

Respond and next play take seconds during play. Reflect and learn happen at breaks, after games, and on film.

Pressure moments

WANT THE MOMENT.

Nerves are normal. They are the body getting ready. The goal is not to eliminate fear. The goal is to stop fear from making the decision (§28).

3. Competitive philosophy

Winning is not the primary measure of development, but competing to win is part of development.

Players should genuinely want to win and compete hard.

Wanting to win is developmental. It creates:

- urgency
- concentration
- resilience
- defensive effort and recovery runs
- communication
- emotional investment

Each group owns a different part:

- **Coach:** long-term perspective
- **Players:** competitive urgency
- **Team:** brave enough to develop while still fighting to win

A team can lose while developing well and can win while developing poorly.

Keep the scoreboard in proportion:

- Before games, talk about what we will do (process goals), not the score.
- Play to win the next action, not to avoid losing.
- No player carries a result alone. We review losses as team problems to solve and never blame them on one player.

Players hear it as: **Want to win. Play for the next action, not the scoreboard.**

Be clear about how roles and playing time are earned. Players who stay in the game more often describe coaches who take both winning and enjoyment seriously, set individual goals, and base playing time on effort and skill.

4. Base structure

The base structure can be viewed as a **4-2-3-1 that can behave like a 4-3-3** depending on which deeper midfielder advances and how the team occupies space.

The formation is a starting structure. The real objective is maintaining useful relationships.

Two deeper midfielders are a developmental bridge: they give security while the team learns to possess, recover, and position. A single pivot can come later.

Role key

Role numbers used in this handbook (the right side takes the lower number):

- goalkeeper (#1)
- outside backs (#2 right, #3 left)
- center backs (#4 / #5)
- pivots, the two deeper midfielders (#6 / #8)
- wingers (#7 right, #11 left)
- striker, the 9 (#9)
- attacking midfielder, the 10 (#10)

Midfield triangle

The 10 and the two pivots form a rotating triangle, not three fixed dots.

One shows. One protects. One threatens.

Who does each job can change:

- If one pivot drops, another player can rise.
- If one pivot advances, another protects underneath.
- If the 10 moves or drops, the triangle adjusts.

The 10 is free to move the triangle, and the pivots adjust to keep its shape. Preserve the relationships, not the coordinates.

The triangle should continually offer different heights and forward, sideways, and backward options.

The pivots help control tempo. Not every touch must accelerate the attack. Sometimes the best action is forward, sometimes a switch or a carry, and sometimes it is securing possession and letting the team reorganize.

Without the ball

Without the ball we usually defend as a 4-4-2 or 4-4-1-1: the 10 either steps up beside the 9 or screens their deepest midfielder, the wingers drop level with the pivots, and the far-side winger narrows. Which option the 10 uses is a game-plan choice.

5. The four moments

When we have it

- Create width, depth, angles, and different heights.
- Progress when an advantage exists.
- Retain possession when progression is not advantageous.
- Carry when space is available.
- Recognize whether the problem is small-space or large-space (§7).
- Manipulate defenders rather than merely pass around them.
- Prepare rest defense before possession is lost.

When we lose it

Immediately decide:

- **Counterpress** if enough teammates are close and the ball can realistically be won quickly.
- **Recover** if the opponent escapes the first pressure.

First player: the ball. Next players: the nearest passes. Everyone else: compact.

- Counterpress as a short, all-out burst of a few seconds.
- If the ball escapes, stop chasing: delay, protect the middle, and recover into shape.

When they have it

- Protect central danger first.
- Stay compact.
- Pressure intelligently.
- Provide cover and balance.
- Delay counters when necessary.
- Anticipate the next transition.

When we win it

- Scan forward immediately.
- Attack an advantage if one exists.
- If not, secure possession and build.

Each position card turns these four moments into role-specific pictures (§30).

6. Possession with purpose

Possession is not an end in itself.

Progress when we have an advantage. Keep the ball when we don't.

We don't play forward because we're impatient. We play forward because we've created an advantage.

If the advantage is not there: calm mind, keep it, move them, create one. The best forward pass is not always the earliest forward pass.

Players should learn to look:

- diagonal
- sideways
- backward
- forward

A temporary training constraint such as **no direct vertical forward passes** can be useful to break the habit of automatic forward play. It should not become a permanent game rule. Keep bans like this short, because a long ban removes a picture players must learn to read (§41).

Short is not automatically safer, and long is not automatically hopeful. See §7 for when a longer pass is the better possession action.

7. Possession at multiple scales — the middle gear

Rondos are valuable for teaching:

- scanning
- body shape
- quick support
- tight-space combination play
- pressing cues
- pressure resistance
- playing through immediate pressure

But rondos teach only one scale of the game, and they should not be the whole possession curriculum.

A major developmental problem occurs when players learn how to survive in a small space but never learn what to do **after they escape it**.

The result can become: **short → short → short → short → trapped → panic clearance**.

Players keep solving the same small-space problem even after a larger-space solution has become available. The team is left with two gears: tight-space short passing and panic clearance.

We need another gear.

The middle gear

The middle gear begins when the team escapes immediate pressure and the field opens. It is large-space possession: carrying, switching, longer intentional passing, weak-side recognition, and exploiting breakaways.

Now players must recognize:

- open grass
- an isolated defender
- a weak side
- a long diagonal lane
- a breakaway opportunity
- an unopposed carrying lane
- space behind the next defensive line
- an opponent that has over-compressed around the ball

At that moment, possession should expand.

The player should ask:

Has the problem changed?

If the pressure is gone, the solution should often change too.

Possible actions include:

- carry 10, 20, or 30 yards into open space
- switch the point of attack
- hit a purposeful 20–40 yard ground or diagonal pass
- break a defensive line
- find the weak side

- attack an isolated defender
- release a runner into space
- accelerate the attack before the defense can recover

Team cue:

SMALL SPACE: COMBINE. BIG SPACE: EXPLOIT.

Possession should expand and contract with the available space. When the field is tight, combine. When the field opens, use it.

We do not want players escaping one crowded area only to recreate another crowded area five yards away.

The purpose of combination play is often to **escape pressure and reach better space**.

Short does not mean possession, and long does not mean direct

A short pass into pressure is not automatically safer or more intelligent than a longer pass into space.

A 30-yard diagonal to a teammate in stride may preserve possession far better than three five-yard passes into a collapsing defense.

Likewise, a longer pass is not automatically “kick and run.” The difference is intention. We want intentional long passing, not blind clearances.

Purposeful distance, not hopeful distance.

Players should learn the difference between:

- clearing the ball because they are panicking
- deliberately using space with a longer pass

The goal of escaping pressure

When we successfully combine through pressure, the reward should often be **more space**. Players must learn to recognize that moment.

Useful coaching questions:

- Did we escape the pressure?
- Is the field bigger now?
- Where is the biggest useful space?
- Can someone carry?
- Is the weak side available?
- Can we attack before they recover?
- Do we need another short pass, or has the problem changed?

The team should not remain psychologically trapped in the rondo after physically escaping it.

Find the biggest useful space.

Training the middle gear

Training should deliberately expose players to changing field sizes and changing solutions.

A useful progression:

1. **Small-space rondo** (such as 4v2 or 5v2): survive pressure, scan, support, and combine quickly.
2. **Escape rondo**: after a set number of passes or a successful split, the ball exits into a much larger area. Players must immediately recognize that the problem has changed. Reward carrying, switching, or attacking space.
3. **Medium directional possession**: use targets, end zones, gates, or neutral players. Teach players to escape one pressure area and find the next useful space.
4. **Large-space 7v7 or 8v8**: intentionally create large weak-side spaces with wide channels or switching incentives. Reward switches, carries, line-breaking passes, and purposeful longer balls.
5. **Full-field positional play**: allow the complete spectrum, from tight combination → escape → expansion → attack → recycle if needed.

Training should not repeatedly constrain players to areas where every useful action is 5–15 yards.

Players need regular experience seeing and executing:

- 20-yard carries
- 25–40 yard diagonal passes
- large switches
- weak-side runs
- breakaway decisions
- attacks against retreating defenders

Choose the space on purpose:

- Small spaces give more touches, more pressure, and faster decisions.
- Big spaces give longer passes, more running, and more carrying and switching.
- Rondos have no goal to attack. Keep them short and sharp, then add direction, targets, or goals.
- Big-space games need real room, in the part of the field where the game problem happens. As a rough guide, a 7v7 plus keepers needs close to half a field, not a penalty box.

A practice curriculum that teaches only small-space possession will produce players who are comfortable only when the game is small.

We want players who can recognize **when to make the game small and when to make it big**.

8. Carrying through space

Passing is not automatically superior to dribbling.

If no defender engages and open space exists, the player should often carry forward until someone must make a decision.

Early teaching cue, called by the whole team: **Carry!**

When everyone calls it, everyone is learning to recognize open space, not just the ball carrier.

The carry should trigger teammates to scan, move, create new angles, and recognize which defender is being fixed.

Over time, the team's Carry! call should fade so the ball carrier recognizes open space herself.

Two related big-space cues work the same way: **Expand** when the team has escaped pressure, and **Go** when an immediate transition or breakaway exists (see [Communication & Movement Fundamentals](#)). Anyone can call them; the player on the ball still owns the decision.

9. Fixing defenders

A central attacking concept:

Make a defender choose.

If a defender steps, someone else becomes freer. If a defender follows a run, space opens elsewhere. If a defender refuses to engage, keep carrying.

Players should progress from asking only “Who is open?” to asking “How can I make someone open?”

10. Deception

Predictable players are easy to defend.

Team cue:

Look like you're changing your mind.

Examples:

- look outside, pass inside
- shape to pass, then carry
- check toward the ball, then run behind
- fake shot, then slip a pass
- slow down, then accelerate
- show one direction with body shape and escape another

The goal is not tricks for their own sake. The goal is to manipulate the defender.

11. Third-player soccer

Sometimes the player receiving the first pass is not the real target. The pattern is **A → B → C**.

Simple teaching phrase:

Sometimes the player you pass to isn't the player you're trying to find.

Timing matters: the third player moves the moment a defender jumps to the first receiver, into the space that defender just left.

12. Pass and move

Move on the pass. Move again after you pass. After passing, players should immediately ask: **Where can I help next?**

They may:

- re-support
- run beyond
- pull a defender
- create width
- fill a vacated space
- provide backward support
- prepare for transition

A player who has just passed is still responsible for influencing the next action.

Team standard:

No hiding. No watching. Influence the game.

13. Everyone is an outlet

Every player is a potential passing option.

If you do not move to become an option, you are making the ball carrier's problem harder.

The player on the ball is not solely responsible for solving pressure. Teammates must help by creating angles, changing height, stretching space, and communicating.

When players are not taught to become options, the ball carrier is left to force play forward or clear it. That looks like her decision problem, but it is a team movement problem.

At every moment, players ask: **Where could I go right now that would make me useful?**

14. Five-lane spacing

Players should understand the general five vertical channels: wide, half-space, center, half-space, and wide.

The lanes are not cages. They are a visual tool for understanding spacing and avoiding unnecessary crowding.

Try to occupy all five lanes, with no two teammates in the same lane at the same height.

15. Weak-side behavior

When the ball is on one side, the far side remains part of the play.

Weak-side players should consider:

- staying wide for the switch
- moving into the half-space
- attacking the far post
- preparing for the next phase

Strong side attracts. Weak side prepares.

Without the ball, the far side has a different job: the strong side pressures, and the weak side tucks in.

The far-side winger narrows to keep midfield compact (§4), and the far outside back tucks toward the center backs (§17).

16. Front-line rotations

The front three should rotate purposefully rather than run in three vertical lanes.

Principle: **Exchange positions without losing attacking shape.**

Someone moves, someone fills, and someone preserves width or depth.

Rotations should be used to exploit different player profiles, create confusion, and get the right type of attacker into the right type of chance.

Every rotation needs a reason:

- drag a defender out of position
- create confusion about who marks whom
- create a central runner
- open a channel
- disguise who will receive

Match profile to phase:

- **Settled attack:** A target or finishing striker pins the center backs, attacks crosses and cutbacks, and gives an aerial target.
- **Open game or transition:** The fastest, most direct attacker carries into space, attacks isolated defenders, runs beyond, and finishes the break herself.

This uses current strengths inside a game. Long-term roles are not assigned by size or speed (§29).

Examples:

- the 9 checks toward the ball while the fastest winger runs beyond
- a winger carries inside while the 9 stays central as the finishing target
- wide and central attackers cross their runs in transition to get the fastest runner central

The 9 and the 10

One comes. One goes.

The 9 and the 10 should not automatically occupy the same height.

- If the 9 checks toward midfield, the 10 can run beyond and temporarily become the highest central attacker.
- If the 10 checks toward the ball, the 9 stays high and pins the center backs.
- They may keep cycling vertically during an attack, and the 9 can reoccupy the high line later.

Positions set the structure; movement changes who occupies the spaces. The 9 does not have to be the highest central player every second.

Diagonal runs

Wingers should not picture only running straight down the touchline. Teach them to:

- start wide, then run diagonally behind
- attack inside when the 9 checks
- exchange lanes with the 9 when useful
- become the temporary central runner in transition
- make crossing runs that force defenders to decide who follows
- arrive at the far post from the weak side

Wingers may occasionally switch sides or cross attacking lanes when doing so creates an advantage without losing team width.

The 9 makes diagonal runs, not only straight ones, and moves center backs intentionally. She lets another attacker become the central runner when that creates the better advantage.

17. Outside back development

Outside backs (sometimes called fullbacks) should learn to:

- support possession
- step into useful space
- intercept proactively
- carry when open
- eventually recognize overlap, underlap, and hold/support choices

If possession is lost after advancing, recovery effort is immediate and maximal. The mentality is proactive going forward and relentless recovering: advancing is not a mistake if it is intelligent and the response after possession loss is immediate.

Outside backs can step and intercept because the players behind them know how to delay. Train both together.

Outside backs step. Center backs and pivots delay until they recover.

Outside back and winger

The outside back and her winger should never blindly occupy the same lane.

- If the winger comes inside, the outside back may provide width.
- If the winger stays wide, the outside back supports underneath or recognizes the underlap or inside support.

Weak-side defending

When the ball is on the opposite side, the far outside back:

- tucks toward central danger
- sees the far-post runner
- stays connected to the center back
- is ready to expand again when possession changes

Both outside backs high at the same time only works when the pivots stay underneath the ball (§20).

Pursuit angles

Recovering defenders should not simply chase the attacker from behind.

Do not run to where the attacker is. Run to where she is going.

Train angled recovery runs that cut off the dangerous path toward goal, then curve to influence the attacker away from danger.

This applies to outside backs, center backs, and any recovering defender. The player-facing version is in [Communication & Movement Fundamentals](#).

18. Building from the back

Center backs should not treat receiving the ball as an emergency. Calm is a weapon.

Safe does not automatically mean clearance.

If time and space exist, solve the soccer problem.

When one center back receives:

- the other opens as a switch option
- midfield adjusts
- outside backs support
- the goalkeeper remains available

The receiving center back should scan among multiple options:

- carry
- play into midfield
- switch
- use an outside back
- use the goalkeeper
- recycle

The horizontal pass between center backs should be available, not automatic. A sideways carry can change the passing angle when forward is closed, and after passing into midfield she steps up to support the next action.

Goal kicks and pressure

- Center backs may receive inside our penalty area. Opponents must stay outside it until the ball is kicked.
- Set up quickly. Under the 2026/27 Laws of the Game, a delayed goal kick can be counted down and become their corner.
- If they press high with everyone, the space is behind them. A driven pass to a runner is intentional possession, not a panic clearance.
- If they drop off to stop it, play short and build.

Short invites the press. Long punishes it. Choose on purpose.

19. Goalkeeper in possession

This handbook is not a goalkeeper training curriculum. Shot-stopping, handling, and positioning belong to goalkeeper-specific training. This section sets her role in team possession.

The goalkeeper is part of the possession structure: the eleventh possession player, available behind the center backs. Back passes are normal soccer, not emergencies.

Goalkeepers should become proficient at:

- receiving back passes
- opening body shape
- using both feet
- playing short under reasonable pressure
- helping switch play
- recognizing where the press has created space

If you decide to come, come. If you decide to play, play.

She does not need to make every save or every pass perfect. She makes the next decision completely, communicates early (before danger develops), organizes the players in front of her, and recovers emotionally right away after a mistake or a goal.

After collecting the ball, the first thought should often be: **Can we restart possession quickly and intelligently?**

Favor quick throws, rolls, and short/medium outlets when they are available. Long punts remain a tactical option, but should not be the automatic default. Under the Laws of the Game, a goalkeeper who holds the ball in her hands for more than 8 seconds concedes a corner kick, with the referee counting down the last 5 seconds.

Quick possession before hopeful distance.

20. Rest defense

Defending begins before possession is lost.

Players underneath the attack should already consider:

- opponent threats
- likely turnover locations
- whether an immediate counterpress would be possible
- which central spaces must remain protected

Rest defense rule of thumb: one more than the attackers they leave up.

- If they leave two forwards up, keep three behind the ball: usually both center backs plus a pivot or a tucked-in outside back.
- The next line (usually the pivots) stays close enough to counterpress the first pass forward.
- Both outside backs high at once? The pivots stay underneath the ball.

This is a rule of thumb from the professional game, not a fixed law.

We do not want attacks that become five players forward followed by a desperate sprint race backward.

21. Delay defending

When the opponent has an advantage, the first defender may need to buy time rather than immediately win the ball.

Sequence:

Protect → slow → show → wait → win

- **Protect:** Stay between the attacker and the most dangerous route to goal.
- **Slow:** Reduce the attacker's speed.
- **Show:** Influence her toward less dangerous space, usually away from the center unless the tactical picture says otherwise.
- **Wait:** Stay balanced. Do not dive in merely because the ball is nearby.
- **Win:** Attack the ball when the touch is poor, the attacker loses balance, support arrives, space disappears, or the challenge becomes favorable.

An excellent delay may contain no tackle. For approach and body shape, see [Communication & Movement Fundamentals](#).

22. Off-ball defensive positioning

Useful shorthand: **See the ball and the most dangerous space or opponent.** The player-facing version is in [Communication & Movement Fundamentals](#).

Do not let a defender become so focused on one mark that she loses the most dangerous information around her.

Body orientation should allow a defender to influence passing lanes, close if the ball arrives, provide cover, and remain useful when possession changes.

Defend from a position you can attack from.

How tight to mark

Protect dangerous space first. Get tighter as the ball and danger get closer.

Get compact first. Then pick up the dangerous opponent in your area.

How close to stand depends on:

- where the ball is
- how dangerous the opponent's position is
- whether she can receive the next pass
- which way she is facing
- whether the passer is under pressure
- what cover is behind the defender

Get tight on dead balls (free kicks, corners, and throw-ins), on crosses, and when stepping to win the ball.

Protecting the box

- Ball wide in our third: the pivots protect the top of the box and the cutback lane.
- Crosses: center backs stay goal-side, see ball and runner, and attack the ball in front of them.
- Ball on the far side: the far-side winger tucks inside to keep midfield compact.

23. Compact defense and pressing

We defend collectively rather than as ten isolated marking assignments.

Priorities:

1. Protect central danger.
2. Stay connected vertically and horizontally.
3. Pressure when appropriate.
4. Provide cover and balance.
5. Shift together.

Pressing together:

- **When one presses, the nearest teammates go with her.** They close the nearest passes, and the line behind moves up.
- **Lock them on one side.** Curve the first run to cut off the switch, and use the touchline as an extra defender.
- **Ball pressured: the back line steps up.** Ball unpressured and the passer can look up: the back line drops.

Useful pressing triggers include:

- poor first touch
- backward pass
- slow square pass
- long square pass across their back line
- receiver facing her own goal
- their goalkeeper receiving under pressure
- ball near the sideline
- isolated receiver
- local numerical advantage

We earn the right to press by staying compact enough to support the first defender.

The nearest defender does not always tackle. Who steps depends on angle, cover, and triggers. Sometimes the nearest player delays while a better-positioned teammate wins the ball.

Center-back partnership

One steps, one covers.

The two center backs never both attack the same problem and never both retreat from it. When one steps to win the ball, the other tucks in behind her and covers the space she left. The pivots follow the same idea: never both leave the center.

Against direct or physical teams

Win the second ball. Then play on the ground.

These are coaching practices for a team without dominant athletes:

- Pressure the passer so long balls are hurried. If she has time to look up, the back line drops before the kick (the step/drop rule above).
- One player contests the first ball, the nearest teammate covers behind for the flick-on, and the pivots surround the drop zone to win the second ball.
- Keep the gap between midfield and the back line small.
- The goalkeeper starts high enough to sweep balls over the top.
- Arrive early and win body position. Not every high ball needs a header (§37).

24. Restarts and set pieces

Restarts are free chances. Organize them quickly; don't improvise them.

As an elite benchmark, not a youth norm, set plays produced just over a quarter of the goals in the 2021/22 Women's Super League in England. Several restart timing rules (goal kicks, throw-ins, the goalkeeper's 8 seconds) are recent Laws of the Game changes; check league adoption each season.

Our corners and wide free kicks:

- attack the front post, the goalmouth, and the far post: arrive, don't camp
- one player at the top of the box for second balls
- enough players home to stop the counter (§20)

Their corners and wide free kicks:

- a few players own the front post and six-yard box while others mark the most dangerous attackers
- one player takes away the short corner
- win the first contact, clear high and wide, then step out together

Other restarts:

- free kicks: quick if an advantage exists, organized if not
- kickoffs: one rehearsed first action that keeps the ball
- goal kicks: read the press (§18)

Throw-ins should be **quick and usually short**:

- two options: one checks short, one threatens long
- sideways or backward throws, which keep the ball more often than long throws down the line into a crowd (in elite men's data)
- the thrower steps back on as the return pass
- no stalling: under the 2026/27 Laws of the Game, a delayed throw-in can be given to the opponent

Keep routines few and simple. Restart jobs are assigned before the match on the [Weekend Role Sheet](#) (§30). For U13 players, set-piece rehearsals count toward heading limits (§37).

25. Game state

Winning: keep it, don't just kick it.

- keep the ball and play more of the game in their half
- lower the risk in our own third, not everywhere
- no cheap fouls or corners near our box

Losing: faster, not frantic.

- quick restarts and one extra runner in the box
- rest defense kept (§20) so one counter does not end the game

We never waste time dishonestly. Game management is a skill, not gamesmanship, and under the 2026/27 Laws of the Game, restart countdowns make stalling costly anyway.

26. Individual 1v1 development

Every player should learn both attacking and defending.

Attacking:

- change direction
- change speed
- protect the ball
- deceive
- attack favorable 1v1s

Defending:

- approach speed
- body angle
- delay
- steering
- tackling
- recovery after being beaten
- managing offside: holding, stepping, and dropping together as a line

No attacking player should be protected from defensive learning, and no defender should be denied on-ball development.

Offside awareness belongs to every defender and midfielder, not only center backs.

27. Risk and emotional safety

Creative soccer requires risk.

At U14, players will make mistakes while learning to receive under pressure, turn, carry, dribble, disguise passes, play through lines, combine, rotate, and make independent decisions.

A mistake should lead to useful reflection, never humiliation.

RESPOND. REFLECT. LEARN. NEXT PLAY.

Teammates should support rather than blame, ridicule, roll eyes, or make a player afraid to try an intelligent action again. The player-facing version is *Mistakes are learning moments*.

Why this matters: in national survey data, girls' sport participation starts to drop around ages 12–13. Girls who quit report more worry about messing up and losing and more self-consciousness than girls who stay, and young athletes who quit report more teasing. A brave, supportive team keeps players in the game long enough to develop.

Team reset: the players choose one shared gesture (for example, brushing the shoulder). After a mistake, the player uses it herself, and teammates and coaches add “Next play.” Practice it in training so it is automatic in games.

Risk is contextual

The same dribble can be brave in the attacking third and careless as the last defender with no cover. Read:

- field location
- pressure on the ball
- cover behind the play
- the game situation

A careless decision ignores that picture. An intelligent risk reads it and still sometimes fails.

We will correct careless decisions, but we will not punish intelligent ideas simply because they did not work.

What coaches avoid

Coaches avoid:

- subbing a player off as a reaction to a brave mistake
- sarcasm, yelling about errors, or comparing players publicly
- punishment running (§36)

Praise brave decisions out loud. Correct details specifically, away from the group when possible and always in view of others.

What tends to happen otherwise: when intelligent mistakes are punished, players stop turning, dribbling, and experimenting, and start hiding from the ball. When a team has no shared mistake culture or positive leadership, players fill the gap by blaming and policing each other. Players are taught not to join that cycle (**When the culture slips**), but setting the standard is the coach's job.

Revisit this list mid-season. Coaching habits slip back without reminders.

28. Courage and responsibility

WANT THE MOMENT.

Youth soccer gives players chances to practice courage before the stakes are truly high. A penalty kick, difficult pass, 1v1 duel, late-game shot, or moment of leadership can feel enormous, but at U14 these are primarily development opportunities.

At U14, the real loss is not missing the penalty. The real loss is avoiding the chance to learn how you respond under pressure.

We should fear wasting developmental opportunities more than we fear temporary failure.

We want players who think: "This is hard. Good. I want the chance to learn from it."

Avoiding pressure is a normal human response, not a character flaw. Even professionals rush when a miss feels costly, and rushed kicks miss more. The more a kick seems to matter, the harder it gets,

so keep each kick in proportion: one kick, one lesson. The goal is not to eliminate fear. The goal is to stop fear from making the decision.

Wanting the moment never means playing through pain or hiding an injury. Coaches never praise a hidden injury as toughness; they thank a player for speaking up. See [Injuries, Recovery, and Return to Play](#).

The player-facing version, with the routine for any pressure moment (Breathe → decide → commit → execute) and the penalty routine (Pick. Place. Breathe. Strike.), is in [Team Culture: Want the moment](#).

Developing hesitant players

Treat reluctance like a weak foot: develop it privately and progressively, never expose it. First ask her privately why she hesitates (trust in her strike, a recent miss, an injury, something social).

- **Validate, then expect.** “Nervous is normal. That’s your body getting ready. You’re ready for this step.”
- **Change the language.** Instead of “Don’t be nervous” or “Calm down,” say “That’s your body getting ready. Do your routine.” Instead of “What if I miss?” ask “Where’s your spot?”
- **Talk skill, not luck.** Never call shootouts a lottery. Separately from the finisher, give target reps to all four corners.
- **One stressor at a time.** Add the next one when she manages the current one.
- **Praise the step forward and the routine,** not only the goal.

Hesitant player ladder, moving up when she is ready (with a nudge): no keeper → keeper → small group watching → full team → named order in a scrimmage shootout → match.

Being watched is a big stressor at this age. Build audience size gradually. Never single out a player in front of the group for declining; follow up one-to-one, in view of others (§44). Support high-expectation players too: the top scorer, captain, or usual taker feels extra pressure.

Practice finisher

Most sessions: one kick each, walking from halfway (about 5 minutes). Occasionally: a full shootout with a set order and sudden death.

1. Walk from halfway. Pick the spot before the walk.
2. Place, step back, whistle, one breath, strike.
3. Goal: celebrate together. Miss: teammates go to her.

Small-group versions are fine for players still climbing the ladder. Change one condition at a time: silent watching or normal noise, telling the keeper your side, the coach announcing the order. Rotate keepers; keepers kick too.

Keep stakes shared and light. Consequences belong to the whole group and stay playful, such as a team target for a small shared reward. Sometimes the target is the routine (spot picked, no rushing), not goals. No running for misses. No public miss counts. Noise, never personal comments. Nobody is “the one who cost us.”

Debrief the process: **Did you pick a spot? Take your time? Commit?**

Shootout order

Everyone trains to be ready; the coach sets the order. Ask during the week who wants a kick, never at the whistle. Before a tournament, share a first five with backups. In lower-stakes games, rotate the order so more players get real kicks. Own the outcome. Only players on the field at the final whistle may kick, and every eligible player kicks before anyone kicks twice (IFAB Laws of the Game; check tournament and league rules each season).

Families never critique a missed penalty or a player who declines one (Parent Partnership). An example development priority built on this section is in §31.

29. Position rotation

Players should not become permanently defined by one position at this age.

In the most competitive matches, prioritize a strong team structure while still looking for reasonable opportunities to broaden roles.

Training, friendlies, scrimmages, and selected match situations should deliberately expand positional understanding.

Compete with our best structure. Develop players beyond that structure.

Coach the player she can be at 15–16, not only this season's position.

A current position should be one position she can play, not the only position she knows how to play.

Make rotation real, not occasional:

- Over a season, every player gets meaningful time in at least one role outside her usual line, in training and in selected games.
- Tell her what the new role is meant to teach her.
- Develop at least two players for every key role, especially center back and the pivots. If only one player can do a job, the team has a development problem.
- When a player asks to rotate, answer with a path: some minutes in another role, rotation in training, or a teammate learning her role while she learns another.

Reliability, size, and confidence

Reliability should not lock a player into one role. A dependable player in a hard position is easy to leave there. That helps the team today and puts the cost on her. Kept there through these years with nothing to compensate, her game narrows, often in ways that only show later. When team needs keep her in one role, compensate on purpose: rotation in training, small-sided games in other roles, and a development priority beyond her match role.

Do not assign roles by current height, speed, or physical maturity. Players mature at different rates, and early size can hide or exaggerate future ability. Center back is the role most often handed to whoever is biggest now, and future coaches may choose positions by different physical profiles (§36).

Players in defensive roles can start to fear the ball because mistakes near our goal feel expensive. Protect their on-ball confidence. The goal is a soccer player who can defend, not a defender. For the player-facing version, see [Team role and development role](#).

30. Advance role preparation

Preparation happens before the game. Thinking happens during the game.

Whenever practical, tell each player her expected **primary role** about 48 hours before a match without announcing the starting lineup. Share roles in person at practice or through the team app with parents included, never as a private message to one player. Roles may still change before or during the match: the notice is for preparation, not a promise of a position or minutes.

Plan on the [Weekend Role Sheet](#). The coach keeps the full table (primary role, secondary role, restart jobs, one focus), and each player receives only her own row. If a player may cover two roles, provide a primary and secondary card to review.

Position cards

Each [position card](#) is a pregame preparation and visualization tool, not a miniature version of this manual. It gives the player:

- her purpose in the role
- a role-specific pregame mindset
- moments to picture
- the four moments in brief
- her most important relationships
- a fallback for when she is unsure
- a few cues

The player reviews the card and mentally rehearses the four moments:

- when we have it
- when we lose it
- when they have it
- when we win it

Players picture the moments; they do not memorize a checklist. The tactical detail lives in this manual.

The last session before a match should be shorter and sharper: small-sided games, role reminders, set pieces. Nothing brand new.

Matchday instruction should mostly be reminders, not first-time teaching.

31. Individual development plans

Every player, starter or reserve, should regularly know:

- one current strength to build on
- one current development priority
- what improvement would look like

These are not permanent labels and should be updated as players improve.

No player on the bench should be confused about what she needs to improve to earn greater opportunity.

When players go long stretches without a priority, progress stalls and they guess at what matters, often wrongly. Players are taught to draft their own and ask about it ([Asking for opportunities](#)). Welcome it.

The conversation

1. Ask her first: “What do you think your next priority is?”
2. Add the coach’s view.
3. Agree on one priority, written as one observable habit.
4. Name what she works on in team training and what she works on outside practice (see the [Home Development Menu](#)).
5. Name her next test: a game, activity, or moment where she will try it.
6. Check the four corners: soccer, physical, mental, and social.
7. Revisit it roughly once a month.

Give development feedback face to face at the field, in view of others. Afterward, the player writes her strength, priority, and what progress looks like in her own words on the [Development Plan](#) and brings it to office hours at the field.

Example priority: **Want the moment.** One pressure rep each week that she chooses (a practice penalty, a free kick, first voice in a huddle), using her routine. Improvement looks like stepping forward and keeping the routine, not scoring every time.

Role and minutes questions

Invite players to ask about roles and minutes: “What would I need to show to earn that?” Answer with one or two observable things and a time to check back. The player does the talking. A parent can help her prepare and may be present. Talks happen in view of others, and every message includes her parent (§44). Welcome specific development requests, and answer with a yes, a not-yet with a clear path, or a training alternative. The player-facing version is [Asking for opportunities](#).

32. Player ownership and peer learning

Players should help each other learn, but should not grade one another.

Help each other learn. Don't grade each other.

Encourage:

- questions
- shared observations
- demonstrations
- useful information
- specific praise

Discourage:

- blame
- bossiness
- public criticism
- acting as another player's authority

Structured peer feedback happens face to face, in coach-led settings such as film sessions or practice debriefs. Praise can be public. Corrections stay small and specific, and major ones come from the coach.

Peer feedback lives on the field, not in the group chat.

The player-facing version is [Help each other learn](#).

Coaches should also periodically ask players what team problem they see and how they might solve it. Give players chances to lead warm-ups, explain principles, and organize small groups ([Team Culture: Everyone leads](#)).

Build coaching literacy too. Players who understand what an activity trains, why it exists, and what it leaves out learn faster, and keep developing when coaching is incomplete. Tell them what problem a session solves, and welcome their questions about reps, roles, and priorities ([How training shapes you](#)).

33. Team development culture

Your effort is part of your teammate's training.

Full-speed defending, transition effort, movement, communication, and honest competition create better repetitions for everyone. Growth happens fastest when the team develops together.

Players hear it as: **We compete hard against each other to make each other better, not to rank each other.**

In practice:

- Keep training games competitive and scored.
- Mix up the teams.
- Avoid running leaderboards that rank teammates.
- For individual work, let players chase their own personal bests.

The player-facing explanation is in [Team Culture](#).

34. Technical practice detail

Passing

- firm when appropriate
- usually on the ground
- targeted to a specific foot or useful space
- played to the foot that tells the receiver which way to turn
- weighted to help the next action

A pass should not merely arrive. It should help the receiver.

The pass tells the receiver which way to turn.

Receiving

Train:

- scanning before arrival
- open body shape
- receiving across the body
- first touch away from pressure
- receiving into the next action
- turning when possible
- protecting when necessary

A good first touch is not merely stopping the ball. It is using the arriving ball to begin the next action.

Receiving under pressure is a skill to develop, not a situation to avoid.

Players who hide from pressure in training will not solve it in games.

Coaching scanning

Coach scanning by naming what to find, not just saying “scan”:

- Where is your open teammate?
- Where is the nearest opponent?
- Where is the space?

Give the cue before small-sided games and in short breaks, then let them play. Train it inside games, not only in drills.

First standard: at least one look before receiving whenever there is time. More looks are not automatically better. What she picks up and uses matters most. This evidence comes from female players aged about 16–18, so its transfer to younger players is untested. For the player-facing receiving posture, see [Communication & Movement Fundamentals](#).

35. Maximum meaningful ball interaction

More meaningful ball interactions generally create more opportunities for development.

Positions do not get equal touches in games. A center back may get a handful while central midfielders get many. At this age, repetitions matter, so training, small-sided games, and rotation should give low-touch roles extra chances to receive, turn, carry, and combine.

Warm-ups should minimize unnecessary lines, waiting, and dead balls.

Standard:

BALL ALIVE. FEET ALIVE. BRAIN ALIVE.

- **Play small-sided games to goals in every session.** They are not a reward saved for the end. (German Football Association guidance through U16: at least 48 net minutes a week per player in small-sided game forms.)
- Watch standing time. If players wait more than they play, change the setup.

Static passing still has a place when a specific technical objective requires it, but ordinary warm-ups should keep players active and engaged. The one planned exception is the injury-prevention warm-up (§36).

36. Athletic development

Players should progressively develop:

- acceleration
- deceleration
- change of direction
- coordination
- balance
- strength
- mobility
- repeat sprint ability
- jumping/landing
- lower-leg stiffness and elasticity

Use age-appropriate plyometrics with emphasis on quality, landing control, and sensible workload.

Athletic work should support soccer, never be used as punishment.

For pain, injuries, and coming back after time out, see [Injuries](#), [Recovery](#), and [Return to Play](#).

Injury-prevention warm-up

This is the exception to the ball-alive warm-up standard (§35).

At least twice a week, all season and in the off-season, the warm-up is a full neuromuscular program: FIFA 11+, or a similar proven program such as Knee Control or PEP. For the youngest players, use 11+ Kids or keep 11+ at level 1.

- It takes about 20 minutes, with every exercise done correctly.
- Teach level 1 until technique is clean, then progress.
- Before games, use the running parts only (Parts 1 and 3).

In teenage girls, programs like this cut ACL injuries by roughly half. **They only work if we actually do them.**

Team plyometric routine

Build a short, low-volume block into practice warm-ups on a regular schedule:

- pogo jumps
- line hops
- snap-downs
- controlled two-leg jumps
- single-leg hops once landings are sound

Coach the outcome:

- **Land soft and quiet.** Stick the landing before the next jump.
- **Knees stay in line over the toes. Don't let them cave in.**
- On cuts: plant, sink the hips, push off with the knee over the foot.
- Quality over quantity.

Count good reps, not minutes.

- Use a few short sets of crisp reps per drill, with full rest between sets.
- Jump first in the session, while players are fresh.
- Stop when landings get loud or knees cave in.
- In a heavy week, jumping is the first thing to cut.

On injury-prevention warm-up days, the warm-up's jumping exercises count as the plyometric block.

Progress volume gradually. Players who want more can use the [Home Development Menu](#), which uses the same cues.

Growth and maturation

Same age, different body age. Girls usually grow fastest around 11–12, but anywhere from about 9 to 15 is normal. On a U13–U14 roster, some players haven't started their growth spurt, some are in it, and some are done.

- During a fast growth phase, expect some temporary clumsiness. Keep teaching landing, balance, and strength, because this age is when that work does the most for knees. Ease off extra volume if she has heel or knee pain.
- Don't mistake early size for talent, or late growth for lack of it. This matters for positions and playing time (§29).

Talk about what bodies can do, never how they look.

Praise strong, fast, balanced, and brave. No comments about weight, shape, or appearance from coaches, parents, or teammates.

37. Heading and head injuries

Head with purpose, not habit.

High-value situations include:

- scoring
- saving a goal
- defending dangerous crosses
- redirecting dangerous balls
- situations where heading is clearly the best tactical action

Players are not obligated to attack every high ball merely because it can be headed. Routine punts do not automatically require an aerial challenge. Beyond high-value situations, whether to head the ball is the player's choice.

Heading limits

Training exposure should remain age-appropriate and consistent with current governing-body guidance. US Club Soccer, which sanctions ECNL, sets heading rules by age group:

- **U13:** Heading practice is capped at 30 minutes and 15–20 headers per player per week. There are no limits in games.
- **U14 and older:** There are no limits, but we still head with purpose, not habit.
- **Playing up:** An 11- or 12-year-old playing up at U14 still follows the U13 practice limits.

Set-piece rehearsals count toward the limit, so walk through runs without live headers when needed. Age groups now follow the Aug 1–Jul 31 school year. Confirm each player's age group, and check current club and league policy, each season.

Teaching aerial duels

In heading situations, most concussions come from contact with another player, not from the ball. When heading is the right choice, teach it well:

- technique first at low ball speed (a lighter ball is fine for learning)
- an early call and a committed jump, or leave it: no late, half-hearted jumps
- arms for balance and space, never elbows
- never jumping into a teammate's or opponent's back

Girls' soccer reports concussions at nearly twice the rate of boys'. Take every head knock seriously.

Head injuries

When in doubt, sit her out.

After any blow to the head or body, watch for:

- dazed, confused, slow to answer, or can't remember what just happened
- unsteady, clumsier than usual, or a change in mood or behavior
- headache, dizziness, nausea, vision problems, or bothered by light or noise
- feeling "foggy" or "not right"

Any of these: she comes out now. If no health care professional is on site to evaluate her, she is done for the day. (ECNL allows a free temporary substitution while an on-site health care professional evaluates her; only that person can clear her back in.)

Call 911 for a seizure, loss of consciousness, repeated vomiting, a headache that gets worse, slurred speech, weakness or numbness, unequal pupils, or not recognizing people or places.

After a concussion, no contact, heading, full training, or games until a health care professional clears her. Never ask a player to "shake it off."

Returning after a concussion

Returning after a concussion is a medical process, not a coaching decision:

- the first 1–2 days: relative rest, light walking, and less screen time
- then step by step (light exercise → soccer drills without contact → full training), at least 24 hours per step, guided by her health care provider, stepping back and calling the provider if symptoms return
- medical clearance (in writing where the state requires it) before any contact, heading, or full training

Most teens recover within a month. If headaches, dizziness, or neck pain last more than about 10 days, the family should go back to her health care provider.

Other injuries and the return to play are covered in [Injuries, Recovery, and Return to Play](#).

38. Safety basics

- Keep an emergency action plan for each venue: field access for EMS, the nearest AED, and copies with every coach, reviewed each season.
- Coaches are trained in CPR and AED use.
- Heat, hydration, lightning, and air quality follow club policy and U.S. Soccer's Recognize to Recover guidance. For lightning, wait 30 minutes after the last thunder or lightning.
- Guidance changes, so check it each season.

Head injuries are covered in §37. Pain, injuries, and returning to play are covered in [Injuries, Recovery, and Return to Play](#).

39. Film study

Players should learn to evaluate their own decisions rather than simply ask whether they played well.

Use the review sequence in the [Film Review Guide](#): pause before the outcome, scan the picture, list the realistic options, play each one forward 2–4 actions, look for a non-obvious or deceptive solution, choose before pressing play, watch what actually happened, judge the decision and the execution separately, and write down one useful lesson. The guide also has one question for each position and a simple game tally that players record on the [Game Reflection](#) sheet.

Team film share

Every player watches a game. At the next practice, go around the group: each player names one thing she needs to work on.

- Players talk only about their own game.
- Each names a behavior, not a feeling.
- Everyone describes rather than judges, and nobody grades teammates.

The coach connects the answers to upcoming training and each player's development priority (§31). Team film stays with the team; see [Sharing film safely](#).

40. Practice design should respond to games

A club curriculum can provide structure, but it should not replace coaching.

If matches reveal recurring problems, upcoming training should address them.

What practice repeatedly exposes players to becomes what they learn to see and solve. Omissions shape habits as surely as drills do:

- Small-space work without large-space work can produce players who are comfortable only when the game is small (§7).
- Technical drills without decisions can produce technique that does not transfer to games (§41).
- Constant instructions can reduce independent problem solving (§43).
- Training disconnected from game problems leaves recurring match problems untouched, until players treat them as normal.
- Position-specific repetition without role variety can narrow development (§29).

When the same problem shows up week after week and training never addresses it, that is a coaching problem to solve, not only a player problem.

Examples in possession:

- automatic vertical play
- poor first touch under pressure
- panicking under pressure instead of supporting possession
- passing short until trapped, then clearing blindly
- no intentional passes beyond short rondo distances
- inability to switch
- poor midfield spacing
- players hiding after passing

Examples in transition, defending, and communication:

- weak transition reactions
- inability to defend 1v1
- lack of communication
- relying on one player to organize the back line

The recurring coaching question should be:

What problem from our games are we teaching them to solve?

Players should be able to answer their version: “What soccer problem did today’s practice teach me to solve?” Answers might be escaping pressure, playing out of the back, creating a 2v1, finding someone between the lines, switching the field, defending a 2v2, pressing, supporting the ball, or turning under pressure. If players cannot name the problem week after week, the practice is not teaching clearly enough.

Session shape: Play → Practice → Play

U.S. Soccer's Play-Practice-Play model gives a simple session shape:

1. **Play:** small-sided games as players arrive, linked to today's problem. The coach mostly watches, adding brief praise, key words, or a question.
2. **Practice:** a directional, game-like activity in the part of the field where the problem happens. Make it easier or harder until players both succeed and fail.
3. **Play:** a bigger game with few stoppages. Use one short break to ask what players noticed.

Finish by checking whether players can say what problem the session worked on.

41. Game-based learning and constraints

Training should contain realistic teammates, opponents, direction, space, pressure, transition, and consequences whenever practical.

Most of practice should look like soccer

Observational studies of youth coaches (all with boys' teams in England) found most practice time went to drills, technique, and fitness with no game context. Skill-learning research suggests moving more time into game-like activities, without throwing out technique work.

Quick check for any activity:

- **Organized:** Is it safe, and does the ball stay in play?
- **Game-like:** Does it include attacking, defending, and transition?
- **Repetition:** Are there many reps of today's problem?
- **Challenging:** Do players both succeed and fail?
- **Coached:** Is the coaching the right amount for the age and level?

If an activity has no opponent, no direction, or no decision, **keep it short and connect it to a game soon after.**

Constraints

Keep the game picture. Change the problem.

A good constraint keeps what players read in real games (opponents, teammates, direction, space). It changes a rule, the space, the numbers, or the scoring so one solution becomes more valuable.

Constraints can temporarily emphasize a principle:

- no forward passes
- touch limits
- required switches
- bonus points for carries
- goals after third-player combinations
- scoring after changing fields

How long they last:

- Keep bans (such as no forward passes, §6) short. A long ban removes a picture players must learn to read.
- Rewards (bonus points for switches, carries, third-player goals) can run longer.
- Specific rules should fade. Shaping the problem through space, numbers, and scoring never stops.

Run the constraint, lift it, then ask the question. For example, play ten minutes of possession with no forward passes, then remove the rule and ask: **When is the forward pass actually better?**

The goal is not players who obey artificial rules. The goal is players who recognize the underlying soccer problem independently. Over time, good decisions should become automatic through pattern recognition: repeated realistic pictures in training build the patterns, and games show whether they stuck.

42. Create advantages

Teach players to recognize and create:

- **numerical advantage** — 2v1, 3v2
- **positional advantage** — receiving between lines
- **spatial advantage** — open grass
- **qualitative advantage** — isolating a player in a matchup she can exploit

Ask:

Where is our advantage? If none exists, how can we create one?

43. Coach communication

A core coaching question:

What did you see?

This encourages players to explain perception and intention rather than simply defend themselves after a mistake.

Questions only help if players are really thinking:

- Ask open questions: “What did you see? What else was possible?”
- Give think time, and accept more than one good answer.
- Ask at natural breaks, not in the middle of a rep.
- Still show and tell when a player doesn’t have the information to solve the problem.

Short cues and pictures (“Make a defender choose”) tend to survive game pressure better than long technical explanations.

Constant instructions have a cost: players learn to wait for the call instead of reading the game. Give information and questions more often than commands.

The best coaching should progressively make the coach less necessary.

44. Communication, availability, and safeguarding

Open. Observable. About soccer.

Club safeguarding policy comes first. Every adult working with the team, parent volunteers included, keeps SafeSport training and background screening current and follows club and US Club Soccer rules. If this handbook and club policy ever differ, club policy wins; check it each season. Safety or abuse concerns are reported immediately, never saved for office hours: 911 in an emergency, local authorities for suspected child abuse, and the U.S. Center for SafeSport (833-587-7233 or its online form).

Coach availability

- The coach stays 15 minutes after every practice. A player can book up to 5 minutes, in person or through the team app with a parent included.
- Film questions come through the team app with a parent included. Other topics are handled in person.
- Parents with a concern about a match wait 24 hours, then ask for a conversation. Safety, health, or welfare concerns are raised right away.
- Talks happen at the field, in view of others. **Out of earshot is fine. Out of sight is not.**
- Parents are welcome to listen in. No talks in cars or closed rooms.
- End office hours while other adults are still at the field. No player waits alone with one coach for her ride.

No player should have to guess how to ask a question.

Messages

- Use one club-approved team app. Parent accounts are the main contact, players join only if the app's age rules allow, and parents stay on every thread.
- Every coach message to a player includes her parent. If a player writes first, add a parent before replying.
- No direct messages on social media, no disappearing-message apps, and no personal social-media connections with players.
- Messages stay about soccer and go out between 8 a.m. and 8 p.m. unless there is a schedule or safety need.
- A parent's written request to stop electronic contact is honored.

Travel

Carpools and transport follow club policy. No player rides alone with one unrelated adult without the parent's advance written permission, and parents pick up their own child first and drop her off last when possible.

The family-facing summary is in [Parent Partnership](#).

45. Team identity

We want a team recognized for players who:

- scan constantly
- communicate
- play with intention
- train at speed
- remain calm in games
- react immediately in transition
- want the moment and step into pressure moments
- support teammates
- take ownership of their development

With the ball, they:

- demand and support the ball
- use deception
- move after passing
- carry open space
- switch play
- exploit weak-side space
- understand third-player combinations
- recognize when the game is small and when it is big

Without the ball, they:

- defend collectively
- delay rather than dive in
- use good pursuit angles

Above everything:

**NO HIDING. NO WATCHING. THINK,
MOVE, INFLUENCE THE GAME.**

What Good Coaching Looks Like

How can a player or a family tell whether a team is being coached well? Not from the scoreboard alone. Losing does not automatically mean poor coaching, and a team can win while developing poorly. Direct play is not automatically bad soccer either: a longer pass with a clear purpose can be exactly right. But at 13 and 14, a team should be learning much more than “get the ball and kick it forward.” Look for evidence of learning, week after week.

The freeze test

Could I freeze this game at a random moment and see evidence of coaching even if I couldn’t hear the coach?

Coaching shows up in what players do without being told: where they stand, when they move, what they look at, and how they react when the ball is lost. On film, pause at a random moment and look at the whole team, not just the ball (see the [Film Review Guide](#)). One freeze proves little. Look for the pattern.

Signs of a well-coached team

No team shows every sign all the time. Ask which column the team lives in most.

Better coached	Less coached
Scan before receiving	Scan after the ball arrives
Triangles and staggered heights	Flat lines
Ball carrier has several options	Ball carrier is isolated
Players move after passing	Players watch after passing
Purposeful progression	Kicking it forward
Coordinated pressing	Individual chasing
Intelligent risk is tolerated	Players fear mistakes
Practices look like the team’s game problems	Generic drills
Players understand why	Players memorize where to stand

Signs of a good development environment

Game day shows only part of the picture. Look at the week too.

- Most practice looks like soccer (opponents, direction, decisions), with little standing in lines.
- Players can say what problem today's practice taught them to solve.
- Every player knows her current priority and how playing time is earned.
- Coaches explain why, offer choices, and ask for player input.
- Effort and improvement are noticed, and good decisions that fail are not punished.
- Players experience more than one role.
- Coaches check on well-being, not only performance.

Warning signs: intimidation, public blame, rivalry between teammates, players afraid to ask for the ball.

What good coaching is trying to do

Knowing the goal makes the signs easier to read:

- **Practice responds to games.** Problems seen on the weekend show up in the next sessions (§40).
- **Most practice looks like soccer:** teammates, opponents, direction, pressure, transition, and consequences.
- **Constraints are temporary tools.** A rule like “no forward passes” is run, lifted, and discussed. The goal is understanding the problem, not obeying the rule (§41).
- **Coaches ask “What did you see?”** and separate decision quality from execution quality.
- **Intelligent risk is tolerated,** so creativity survives.
- **Players learn relationships and principles,** not coordinates.
- **Every player has a development target** and a path toward more opportunity.
- **The aim is complete players,** not only the strongest lineup this weekend.
- **The coach becomes less necessary over time,** and learning is visible in games even when the coach is silent.

Reasonable coaches pursue these goals in different ways. We should be attached to good principles, not rigidly attached to one method.

If something seems to be missing

This is not about scoring a coach. Reasonable coaches disagree about methods and tactics, and one bad session proves little. It is about noticing what your environment teaches well, what may be missing, and what those gaps may be teaching you, so you can keep developing.

Separate three things:

- **Coaching disagreement:** a different method or tactic than you expected. Often fine.
- **Coaching limitation:** something important is under-taught, left out, or rarely reinforced.
- **Developmental consequence:** that gap starts shaping habits, confidence, decisions, role, or team culture.

Focus on the second and third, and look at patterns over weeks, not single practices.

If this keeps happening	It tends to teach	What you can do
Possession work is almost always in tight spaces	Short passing after pressure is escaped, then panic clearances	Train longer passing and carrying at home; watch for big-space moments on film
Players aren't taught to become options	Forced forward passes, isolated ball carriers, and blame on the player with the ball	Keep asking where you could go to be useful; study off-ball movement on film
Intelligent mistakes are punished	Fear of turning, dribbling, and trying things	Keep taking intelligent risks; judge the decision separately from the outcome
No shared mistake culture or positive leadership	Blame, eye-rolls, teammates policing each other	Don't join it; support, inform, and praise (<i>When the culture slips</i>)
One player stays in one role all season	A narrower game, few touches in low-touch roles	Build missing skills in small-sided games and at home; ask for rotation or role-specific work
No development feedback for long stretches	Stalled progress and guessing at what matters	Draft your own priority and bring it to office hours
The same game problem recurs and practice never addresses it	The problem starts to feel normal	Make it your film theme and home work; ask about it as a question
Constant instructions from the sideline	Waiting to be told instead of reading the game	Scan and decide first; on film, notice what you saw before the call
Rules like "two touch" or "stay wide" are never explained or lifted	Obedying the rule after the picture has changed	Ask what problem the rule solves; notice when the picture changes
Roles assigned by current size or speed	A narrow role that may not fit the player you become	Keep building the skills your body isn't doing for you yet
Low-touch roles with no extra reps in training	On-ball skills falling behind	Replace the reps: small-sided games, rondos, wall work, pickup

These patterns are meaningful. A team that repeats the same developmental problem while training never addresses it, a player who gets no development feedback for months, a player fixed in one role through these years with nothing to compensate, and a mistake culture that produces fear and peer blame can all stall a player who is working hard. None of that proves the coach doesn't care, and none of it makes your development someone else's job.

Your coach shapes your environment. You still own your development.

Questions a player can ask herself

- **“What soccer problem did today’s practice teach me to solve?”** Escaping pressure, switching the field, defending a 2v2. If players cannot answer week after week, that is meaningful evidence that practice is not teaching clearly.
- **“Where could I go right now that would make me useful?”** Ask it all game, with and without the ball.
- **“Will this environment make me a better player?”** Judge it over a season, not a weekend. Game roles hand out touches unevenly, so training, small-sided games, and rotation should give her the repetitions her match role does not.
- **“How do I make sure I still become the player I want to become?”** Her team role is where she helps the team today. Her development role is the complete player she is becoming. See [Team role and development role](#).

If the answers raise concerns, start with a conversation, not a verdict. Players, see [Asking for opportunities](#); families, see [Parent Partnership](#). Coaches can use every question here as a self-check: the best coaching progressively makes the coach less necessary.

Parent Partnership

Parents are partners in a player-first development environment. Players do the playing and, more and more, their own thinking and talking. Coaches teach, plan, and set roles. Families make the rest possible: rides, meals, sleep, and the steady message that she is loved whatever the score. To judge the coaching itself, see [What Good Coaching Looks Like](#).

Player first

Player first. Parent second. Safety immediately.

- Questions about role, minutes, or development start with the player. She books office hours, and you help her prepare (see [Asking for opportunities](#)).
- If you still have a concern about a match, wait 24 hours, then ask the coach for a conversation.
- Any safety, health, or welfare concern is raised right away, with no waiting period. For abuse or an emergency, see “Communication and safeguarding” below.

On the sideline

- Cheer for the whole team, especially effort and brave ideas.
- Leave instruction to the coaches. Two voices giving different directions confuse players.
- Leave officials alone.
- Never criticize a player who misses or declines a penalty. After any mistake, cheer the next play.

Talk about what bodies can do, never how they look.

Praise strong, fast, balanced, and brave. No comments about weight, shape, or appearance from coaches, parents, or teammates.

After the game

- “I love watching you play.”
- Let her start the soccer conversation: “Want to talk about it now or later?”
- Save critique for later. Keep it honest and short, and use the team’s words: What did you see? Next play.
- No player carries a result alone. Don’t replay one moment as the reason the game was lost.

Helping at home

Use the team's words (scan, carry, next play), offer rather than require, and leave new tactical instruction to the coach. The [Home Development Menu](#) has short, optional sessions she can choose from. Count the whole week: all organized sport adds up. The National Athletic Trainers' Association recommends at least two days a week free of organized training and games. Protect sleep; teens need 8–10 hours ([Recovery basics](#)).

If something seems to be missing

Every environment teaches some things well and others less. If you see a pattern over weeks (the same game problem never addressed, no development feedback, one role all season, or fear after mistakes), help her notice it without turning it into a verdict on the coach. Ask what she gets lots of reps at and what she gets almost none of. Help her fill gaps with the [Home Development Menu](#) and pickup games, and help her prepare a good question for office hours. Keep criticism of the coach out of her hearing. See [What Good Coaching Looks Like](#).

Health signals

Fuel and periods. Growing athletes need enough total food, including iron, calcium, and vitamin D. Eating too little for the training load (low energy availability) harms both health and performance. Once periods have started, going about 3 months or more without one is not a normal part of hard training. The same goes for no period by age 15, or within 3 years after her breasts started to develop. See a doctor.

Head injuries. After any blow to the head or body, a player who seems dazed, unsteady, or “not right” comes out now. Unless a health care professional on site clears her, she is done for the day.

When in doubt, sit her out.

Returning after a concussion is a medical process led by her health care provider, not a coaching decision: step by step, and cleared (in writing where your state requires it) before contact, heading, or full training. Tell the coach about any concussion, meaningful injury, or medical restriction, even outside soccer, so she can be supported safely ([Injuries](#), [Recovery](#), and [Return to Play](#)).

Communication and safeguarding

Club safeguarding policy comes first. Every team adult, parent volunteers included, keeps SafeSport training and background screening current and follows club and US Club Soccer rules. If this handbook and club policy differ, club policy wins. Check it each season. Safety or abuse concerns are reported immediately, never saved for office hours: 911 in an emergency, local authorities for suspected child abuse, and the U.S. Center for SafeSport (833-587-7233 or its online form).

Open. Observable. About soccer.

- Team news and film questions go through one club-approved team app. Parent accounts are the main contact, and players join only if the app's age rules allow.
- Every coach message to a player includes her parent, even if she writes first. No social-media DMs or disappearing-message apps. A parent's written request to stop electronic contact is honored.
- Office hours: the coach stays 15 minutes after every practice, and a player can book up to 5 minutes, in person or through the team app with a parent included.
- Talks happen at the field, in view of others. **Out of earshot is fine. Out of sight is not.** Parents may listen in. No talks in cars or closed rooms; no player waits alone with a coach for her ride.
- In carpools, no player rides alone with an unrelated adult without advance written parent permission, and drivers pick up their own child first and drop her off last when possible.
- Please take SafeSport's free parent training each year. It explains what good communication and supervision look like and how to raise a concern ([Sources and Further Reading](#)).

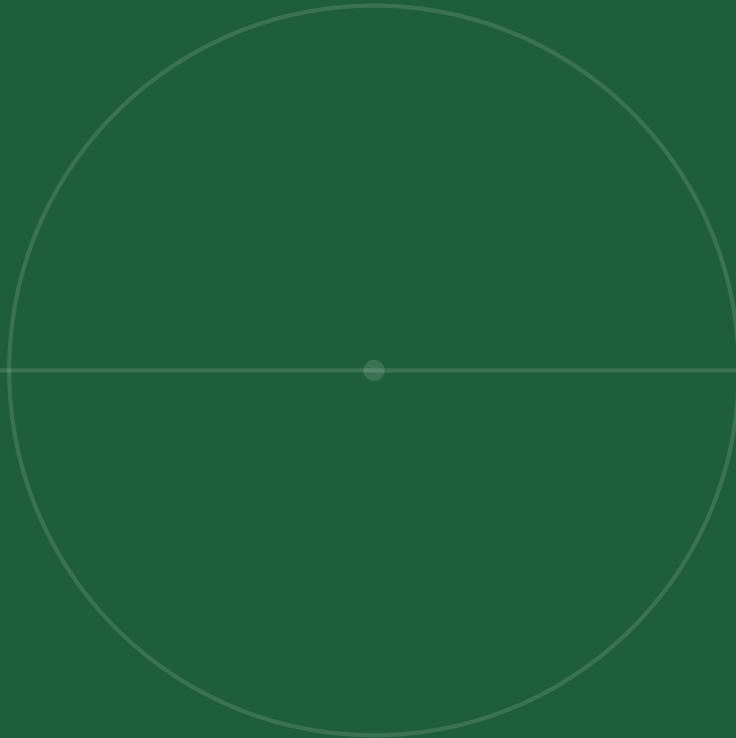
Film

Team film stays with the team. Watch game film through the team's private link or app, and don't repost it publicly. No recording in locker rooms, restrooms, or changing areas. If you want a clip of your daughter taken down, ask, and it comes down. See [Sharing film safely](#).

PART FOUR

Templates and Resources

Printable forms and the sources behind this handbook.



Weekend Role Sheet

Roles go out about 48 hours before the match, in person or through the team app with parents included. This is not the starting lineup, and roles may still change. The coach keeps the table; each player receives only her own row, then reviews the [position card](#) for each role and pictures its moments. Continue on a second sheet as needed.

Preparation happens before the game. Thinking happens during the game.

Match	Date	Opponent

Player	Primary role	Secondary role	Restart jobs	One focus

TEMPLATE

Game Reflection

From one half of film, count each action and note what a clip teaches you. The [Film Review Guide](#) explains each count.

Game	Date	Position

Simple game tally

Action	Tally	Notes
Received the ball		
Received after at least one scan		
Received facing forward or on the half-turn		
Broke a line with a pass or carry		
Moved to a new angle after passing		
Won or blocked the ball by reading the play		
Asked for the ball		

A scan is a head turn away from the ball in the 5 seconds before your first touch. Skip clips where you cannot clearly see the head, and compare scanning only with games in the same position.

Three-part self-review

One thing I did well	One thing I need to improve	One solution I want to try

Compare with your own last game, not with teammates.

TEMPLATE

Development Plan

Start with your own view, then agree on one priority with the coach and check in roughly once a month. No priority from the coach yet? Draft your own and bring it to office hours to check. For work outside practice, use the [Home Development Menu](#).

Player	Date	Next check-in

Topic	In my own words
My strength to build on	
My development priority (one habit, chosen with the coach)	
What progress will look like	
What I work on in team training	
What I work on outside practice	
My next test (game, activity, or moment)	
Four corners check (soccer, physical, mental, social)	

Check-in notes

Date	What I tried	What changed	Next step

The player writes this in her own words and brings it to office hours at the field.

Sources and Further Reading

The principles in this handbook were checked against publicly available federation, academy, and research sources, including ideas from Ajax, Barça, The FA, and U.S. Soccer youth guidance. This handbook is not an official program of any of them.

Research entries say who was studied. Almost none studied players as young as U13–U14, so treat findings as guidance, not proof, for our team. Links were checked in September 2026. Laws, league rules, safeguarding policies, and streaming services change, so check the source each season. Entries without a year are web pages that change over time or documents without a clear date.

Coaching methodology and practice design

Play-Practice-Play overview — U.S. Soccer Coaching Education (copy hosted by Iowa Soccer)
https://www.iowasoccer.org/wp-content/uploads/sites/169/2023/09/coach_play_practice_play.pdf

The FA's 4 Corner Model — The FA, 2020
<https://www.thefa.com/bootroom/resources/coaching/the-fas-4-corner-model>

Football youth academy models: La Masia vs Ajax — Barça Innovation Hub, 2026
<https://barcainnovationhub.fcbarcelona.com/blog/the-models-of-youth-teams-in-football/>

Practice activities and instruction used by youth soccer coaches — Ford, Yates & Williams, Journal of Sports Sciences, 2010 (25 coaches of boys' U9–U16 teams in England)
<https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/20419591/>

Training Philosophy Germany (at least 48 net minutes a week in small-sided games through U16) — German Football Association (DFB), in German
<https://www.dfb.de/mehr-fussball/dfb-akademie/trainingsphilosophie-deutschland>

Tactics and the game model

Further measures to improve match flow (restart countdowns) — The IFAB, 2026
<https://www.theifab.com/news/the-ifab-introduces-further-measures-to-improve-match-flow-and-player-behaviour/>

High pressing the goal kick (FIFA U-17 Women's World Cup 2025) — FIFA Training Centre
<https://www.fifatrainingcentre.com/en/game/tournaments/fu17wwc/2025/part-2-high-pressing-the-goal-kick.php>

Attacking styles and goal-scoring in the 2021/22 Women's Super League — Craven, Oxenham & Ranaweera, PLOS ONE, 2025 (professional women in England)
<https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC11801634/>

Throw-in tactics and possession — Casal et al., PLOS ONE, 2023 (professional men in Spain's La Liga, 2021–22)

<https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC10650988/>

Perception, scanning, and film study

Scanning, contextual factors, and performance in Premier League players — Jordet et al., Frontiers in Psychology, 2020 (professional men)

<https://www.frontiersin.org/journals/psychology/articles/10.3389/fpsyg.2020.553813/full>

Optimizing scanning in youth female football: the role of verbal instruction — Hintermann et al., European Journal of Sport Science, 2025 (Swiss U19 female players)

<https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC12535765/>

“Heads Up Girls!” A training intervention to improve scanning — Hintermann et al., Frontiers in Sports and Active Living, 2025 (Swiss female players, mean age about 17)

<https://www.frontiersin.org/journals/sports-and-active-living/articles/10.3389/fspor.2025.1602099/full>

Fooled by performance randomness: overrewarding luck — Gauriot & Page, Review of Economics and Statistics, 2019 (professional soccer)

<https://ideas.repec.org/a/tpr/restat/v101y2019i4p658-666.html>

Technique and home practice

Non-dominant leg training improves both legs — Haaland & Hoff, Scandinavian Journal of Medicine & Science in Sports, 2003 (39 players aged 15–20 on one team)

<https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/12753491/>

Footedness in world soccer: an analysis of France '98 — Carey et al., Journal of Sports Sciences, 2001 (236 players at the men's World Cup)

<https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/11695507/>

Psychology, culture, and pressure

Keeping Girls in the Game — Women's Sports Foundation, 2020 (U.S. girls and boys aged 7–17)

<https://www.womenssportsfoundation.org/wp-content/uploads/2020/02/Keeping-Girls-in-the-Game-FINAL-web.pdf>

Effects of a motivational climate intervention for coaches on young athletes' anxiety — Smith, Smoll & Cumming, Journal of Sport & Exercise Psychology, 2007 (girls' and boys' youth basketball)

<https://journals.humankinetics.com/view/journals/jsep/29/1/article-p39.xml>

Developing a ritual for overcoming mistakes — Positive Coaching Alliance

<https://positivecoach.org/resource-zone/developing-a-mistake-ritual/>

Expert statement on psychological preparation for football penalty shootouts — Wilson, Wood & Jordet, BASES (professional shootout research)

https://www.cases.org.uk/imgs/545_expert_statement_on_psychological_preparation_for_football_penalty_shootouts557.pdf

Celebrating goals in penalty shootouts — Moll, Jordet & Pepping, Journal of Sports Sciences, 2010 (men's World Cup and European Championship shootouts)

<https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/20544488/>

Why and how athletes can have tough talks with their coaches — TrueSport, 2022

<https://truesport.org/respect-accountability/athletes-tough-talks-coach/>

Health and safety

Head injuries (heading guidelines by age group) — US Club Soccer

<https://usclubsoccer.org/headinjuries/>

HEADS UP: responding to a suspected concussion — CDC

<https://www.cdc.gov/heads-up/response/index.html>

HEADS UP: returning to sports after a concussion — CDC

<https://www.cdc.gov/heads-up/guidelines/returning-to-sports.html>

HEADS UP: returning to school after a concussion — CDC

<https://www.cdc.gov/heads-up/guidelines/returning-to-school.html>

Association of sex with adolescent soccer concussion — Bretzin et al., JAMA Network Open, 2021 (Michigan high school soccer players)

<https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC8080231/>

ACL injury prevention — U.S. Soccer Recognize to Recover

<https://www.recognizetorecover.org/acl-injury-prevention>

Consensus statement on paediatric ACL injuries — International Olympic Committee (Ardern et al.), British Journal of Sports Medicine, 2018 (expert consensus on children and adolescents)

<https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC5867447/>

The 11+ manual — FIFA Medical Assessment and Research Centre (school-hosted copy)

https://www.horacemann.org/uploaded/Athletics/sportsmedicine/strengthconditioning/11plus_workbook_fifa.pdf

Comprehensive warm-up programme to prevent injuries in young female footballers —

Soligard et al., BMJ, 2008 (girls aged 13–17)

<https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/19066253/>

Youth sport specialization recommendations — National Athletic Trainers' Association, 2019

https://www.nata.org/sites/default/files/2025-08/youth_sports_specialization_recommendations.pdf

Teen sleep duration health advisory — American Academy of Sleep Medicine, updated 2016

<https://aasm.org/advocacy/position-statements/teen-sleep-duration-health-advisory/>

Chronic lack of sleep and sports injuries in adolescent athletes — Milewski et al., Journal of Pediatric Orthopaedics, 2014 (112 athletes aged 12–18 at one U.S. school)

<https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/25028798/>

Osgood-Schlatter disease (knee pain) — American Academy of Orthopaedic Surgeons, OrthoInfo

<https://www.orthoinfo.org/diseases--conditions/osgood-schlatter-disease-knee-pain/>

Call or text 988 (free, 24/7) — 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline
<https://988lifeline.org/>

Safeguarding

Minor Athlete Abuse Prevention Policies (MAAPP) — U.S. Center for SafeSport
<https://maapp.uscenterforsafesport.org/>

Prevention policies — US Club Soccer
<https://usclubsoccer.org/safeguarding-compliance/prevention-policies/>

MAAPP for parents, including free parent training — U.S. Center for SafeSport
<https://maapp.uscenterforsafesport.org/how-it-works/for-parents/>

Report a concern — U.S. Center for SafeSport
<https://uscenterforsafesport.org/report-a-concern/>

Age groups and where to watch

Age group cut-off update for the 2026–27 season — US Club Soccer, 2025
<https://usclubsoccer.org/age-group-cut-off-update-for-2026-27-season/>

ECNLTV (paid; ECNL and ECNL RL games) — ECNL, via Team1Sports / Hudl TV
<https://team1sports.com/ecnlv/>

Girls Academy National Finals — Girls Academy
<https://girlsacademyleague.com/national-finals/>

NWSL matches scheduled for Victory+ move to NWSL+ — NWSL, July 2026
<https://www.nwslsoccer.com/news/nwsl-matches-scheduled-for-victory-to-stream-on-nwsl-beginning-immediately>

How to Watch — NWSL
<https://www.nwslsoccer.com/how-to-watch>

CBS Sports brings back Women's Super League US broadcast rights — Sportcal, 2026
<https://www.sportcal.com/news/cbs-sports-brings-back-womens-super-league-us-broadcast-rights/>

For current TV and streaming partners, check each league's How to Watch page.